GARSEF
GREATER AUSTIN REGIONAL SCIENCE AND ENGINEERING FAIR
A Program of the Austin Science Education Foundation

Junior and Senior Division Handbook 2027







Junior Division (middle school) includes 6th-8th grade

Senior Division (high school) includes 9th-12th grade

Table of Contents

Table of Contents **2**
Important Dates to Know **3**
Introduction **4**
Rules for Participating in GARSEF **5**
Ethics Statement 5
Scientific Integrity: A Core Value 5
Eligibility 6
General Requirements 8
Roles & Responsibilities of Students & Adults **9**
What's New in 2027 ..... **12**
New for 2027: GARSEF 12
New for 2027: ISEF Modifications 12
Registration Information **15**
STEM Wizard 15
STEM Wizard Training Materials 15
Registration Steps 15
Project Categories - GARSEF **18**
Guidelines for the Use of AI in Science Fair Projects **19**
Project Display **22**
Message from the GARSEF Scientific Review Committee **24**
Top GARSEF Paperwork Problems to Avoid 24
Judges and Volunteers **26**
Judging Criteria 26
Fair Week Expectations **27**
Schedule 27
What Students can expect during judging 27
What Teachers and Parents can expect during judging 28
Awards and Award Ceremony 28
Frequently Asked Questions **29**
GARSEF Website **31**
APPENDIX: Project Forms **32**
Sample Junior Division Forms 32
Sample Senior Division Forms (ISEF) 32
Signatures for STEM Wizard Forms **33**
Junior Division Forms **34**
Senior Division Forms **38**

Important Dates to Know

Before Fair **Sep 2, 2026** 5:00 - 6:30 pm	**Teacher: Jr/Sr Returning Teacher Orientation** on-line (participated > 3 years)
Sep 3, 2026 5:00 - 6:30 pm	**Teacher: Jr/Sr New Teacher Orientation** on-line (participated < 3 years)
Oct 14, 2026 5:00 pm	**Student: STEM Wizard Account Creation Deadline** - Milestones 1 & 2 (Project + Student Information)
Nov 18, 2026 5:00 pm	**Student: Files and Forms Recommended Submission**, including pre-approval signatures
Jan 4, 2027 5:00 pm	Abstract in "Files and Forms" and Additional Information milestone added in STEM Wizard.
Jan 8, 2027 5:00 pm	**Teacher: Junior/Senior School Pre-Registration Form Submission**
Jan 15, 2027 5:00 pm	**Student: Abstract and Additional Information milestone Recommended Submission** in STEM Wizard
Jan 21, 2027 5:00 pm	**Teacher: Project Registration Submission Deadline:** deactivate students who are not advancing to GARSEF in STEM Wizard, and submit Senior Division plagiarism reports. **All milestones** for advancing students must be complete.
Feb 5, 2027 5:00 pm	**Student: Submissions for Judges Review milestone Deadline**
Fair Setup **Feb 17, 2027** 2:30 - 7:00 pm	**Student, Parent, or Teacher: Check-in and set-up of projects** at Palmer Event Center
Day of Fair! **Feb 18, 2027** 9:00 am - 12:00 pm	**Student: Senior Division judging**
Feb 18, 2027 1:00 - 3:45 pm	**Student: Senior Division top-tier judging** (students will be notified during morning judging if they advance)
Feb 18, 2027 **1:30 - 4:30 pm**	**Student: Junior Division judging**
Feb 18, 2027 7:00 - 9:00 pm	**Everyone: Junior and Senior Award Ceremony**
Feb 18, 2027 9:00 - 9:30 pm	**Student: Dismantle projects**

NEW for 2027

Full list of changes: What's New Section
ISEF Rules and Guidelines

NEW for GARSEF 2027

→ **New Dates**: STEM Wizard Account Creation (Oct 14, 2026-deadline), Files and Forms (Nov 18, 2026-recommended)
→ **School Pre-Registration Form** required for all schools to confirm estimated project counts and paperwork completion.
→ **New Categories:** Computational Biology and Bioinformatics (CBIO) and Biomedical Engineering (ENBM) added to both Junior and Senior Divisions.
→ **Participation Agreement:** (Senior Division) now completed in STEM Wizard.
→ **GARSEF Website:** Reorganized; new Parent/Guardian Information page added.
→ **GARSEF Merchandise** will be available for pre-order purchase at the end of January.

NEW ISEF Changes and Clarifications for 2027

→ **Artificial Intelligence (AI)** may be used as a resource but must be cited and given proper acknowledgment. A student is expected to do independent work and all materials presented must be in the researcher's own words. A student may not use generative AI to write the research plan, abstract, poster or to create citations (it is known to hallucinate and falsify references).
→ **Mentorship disclosure:** All students are required to disclose whether they received paid or unpaid mentorship.
* Junior Division Form 2C JR: Middle School Mentor and Research Location Form - required for some projects
* Senior Division - Form 2C required for some projects.

Human Participant Rules → See full changes here.
→ Students are prohibited from disclosing research data from their study and/or from providing advice, diagnostic or medical information to participants.
→ Clarification on studies with minors involving a survey both written and online.

Vertebrate Animal Rules → See full changes here.
→ Clarification for agricultural/aquacultural projects.

PotentiallyHazardous Biological Agents → See full changes here.
→ Clarification on prohibited studies involving the use of prions, commercially available purified prion-like proteins, and plasmids that contain genes encoding prion-like proteins.
→ Clarifications on studies pertaining to water sampling during a Harmful Algal Bloom (HAB)
→ Clarification on studies involving animal models that have been bred to express prion-like proteins
→ Update on exempt studies involving various bacteria.

Hazardous Chemicals, Activities, or DevicesRules → See full changes here.
→ New restrictions on projects involving chemicals that are listed as causing carcinogenic, teratogenic, or reproductive system damage on the SDS.
→ Update on studies using DEA Scheduled substances.

Forms → See full changes here.
→ **Student Support Disclosure Form (2A)** - *NEW, required*
→ **Qualified Scientist Form (2B)** - *Formerly Form 2*
→ **Regulated Research Institutional/Industrial Setting Form (2C)** - *Formerly Form 1C*

Introduction

The **Junior Division** of the Greater Austin Regional Science and Engineering Fair (GARSEF) is a competitive event for 6th-8th graders. The **Senior Division** is a competitive event for 9th-12th graders. All participating students are required to register their projects through the STEM Wizard registration system and follow all the Regeneron International Science and Engineering Fair (ISEF) Rules; while high schoolers (**Senior Division**) will complete the necessary ISEF forms, middle schoolers (**Junior Division**) will submit the Texas MS Safety and Consent Form.

Awards are given for 1st - 5th place winners in each category for each division as well as special awards. 1st - 2nd place winners advance to the Texas Science and Engineering Fair. The top **Junior Division** projects in each category are nominated for the Thermo Fisher Scientific Junior Innovators Challenge. Six projects in the **Senior Division** are selected as Best of Fair winners and will advance to the Regeneron ISEF competition.

2025-2026 Participating Schools

A&M Consolidated HS
ACE Academy MS
Akins HS
Austin Achieve HS
Austin Classical HS
Austin HS
Austin Peace Academy
Austin Rising MS
Basis Cedar Park
Basis Pflugerville
Bee Cave MS
Bohls MS
Calvary Episcopal School MS
Canyon Ridge MS
Canyon Vista MS
Cedar Park HS
Cedar Valley MS
Challenger School (Avery Ranch) MS
Classical Conversations (Round Rock) MS
College Station HS
Del Valle MS
Doral Academy of Texas MS
Dripping Springs HS
Early College (Leander) HS
Grisham MS
Harmony School of Endeavor (Austin)
Harmony School of Excellence (Austin)
Harmony Science Academy (Leander)
Hernandez MS
Hill Country MS
Holy Family Catholic School (Austin)
Hyde Park MS
Kealing MS
Ladybird Montessori MS
Lake Travis HS
LASA HS
Leander HS
Leander MS
Liberty Hill HS
Long-View Micro School MS
Manor New Technology HS
McNeil HS
Meridian School MS
Murchison MS
Pearson Ranch MS
Pflugerville MS
Priddy MS
Renaissance Academy
Round Rock Christian Academy
Round Rock HS
Rouse HS
Running Brushy MS
Santa Rita MS
St. Dominic Savio Catholic HS
St. Michael's Catholic Preparatory HS
St. Stephen's Episcopal (Wimberley) MS
Taylor MS
Vandegrift HS
Veritas Academy HS
Vista Ridge HS
Walsh MS
Wayside Sci-Tech MS
Wayside Sci-Tech HS
West Ridge MS
Westlake HS
Westwood HS

Rules for Participating in GARSEF

Ethics Statement

Students are expected to abide by the Society for Science's Ethics Statement. Scientific fraud and misconduct are not condoned at any level of research or competition. This includes: plagiarism; forgery; fabrication or falsification of data; inappropriate use of AI; unattributed use of other works, including use of other researcher's work without permission and the presentation of other researcher's work as one's own. Fraudulent projects will fail to qualify for competition in GARSEF as well as affiliated fairs, including ISEF. GARSEF reserves the right to revoke recognition of a project subsequently found to have been fraudulent.

Scientific Integrity: A Core Value

Students are expected to abide by the Society for Science's statement on integrity. "Society for Science expects students competing in all of our STEM research competitions — the Regeneron Science Talent Search, Regeneron International Science and Engineering Fair and Thermo Fisher Scientific Junior Innovators Challenge – as well as our affiliated science fair network to hold themselves to the highest ethical standards. Scientific integrity is central to the credibility, reliability and progress of science. At a time when misinformation is at an all-time high, and technological advancements like AI are challenging the way we interact, it is vital that scientists of every age adhere to principles of honesty, transparency and objectivity."

Eligibility

1. Any student in grades 6-12 or equivalent, enrolled in a public, charter, private, parochial, or home school in the region covered by GARSEF is eligible to participate in GARSEF. 6th-8th graders compete in the **Junior Division**, and 9th-12th graders compete in the **Senior Division**.
2. If a school, district, or other entity that the student falls under has a science fair program, then only students in that program and that are advanced by the program may participate in GARSEF.
3. Students may not have reached 20 years of age, on or before May 1st of the event year.
4. English is the official language of ISEF/GARSEF. Student project boards and abstracts must be in English.
5. Students are not permitted to simultaneously enter another regional ISEF-affiliated science fair.
6. Team projects may have a maximum of three team members. Each team is encouraged to appoint a team leader to coordinate the work and act as spokesperson. However, each member of the team should be able to serve as spokesperson, be fully involved with the project, and must be familiar with all aspects of the project. The final work should reflect the coordinated efforts of all team members and will be evaluated using similar rules and judging criteria as individual projects. Teams must be set up prior to the start of the project (including documentation). Team members may not be added or removed once the project begins. A mixed team with members from different schools or geographic regions (within the United States) may compete at GARSEF as long as one team member is from the GARSEF region. The

team can only compete under one of the schools and in one regional fair. The students will need permission from all involved schools to compete at the selected fair.

7. Projects that are demonstrations, library research or informational projects, explanation models or kit-building are not appropriate for GARSEF.
8. Artificial Intelligence (AI) may be used as a project resource but must be cited and given proper acknowledgements. All materials presented must be in the researcher's own words. We recognize that AI is widely used in student research. Please review the GARSEF Guidelines for AI Use and ISEF AI Guidelines for appropriate use.
9. All science and engineering disciplines are represented, and projects compete in one chosen category. See the GARSEF Category List for the regional fair options. Review a complete list of ISEF categories and sub-categories with definitions for more information.
10. A research project may be a part of a larger study performed by professional scientists, but the project presented by the student must be only their own portion of the complete study (See Ethics Statement above).
11. Continuation/research progression projects are allowed. Review ISEF rules for more. information.

General Requirements

1. GARSEF is affiliated with the Regeneron International Science And Engineering Fair (ISEF) and only projects following ISEF rules are permitted to participate in our fair. Make sure to review these rules before starting a project.
2. All students competing in GARSEF must adhere to all of the rules as set forth in this document and by ISEF. **In the case of a conflict between the ISEF and GARSEF rules, GARSEF rules supersede ISEF rules**:
    a. In addition to ISEF rules, all BSL-2 projects must be conducted at a Regulated Research Institute (RRI) supervised by a qualified scientist.
    b. **Junior Division** students are NOT allowed to perform any research or submit any projects in which the student has designed or utilized firearms or any type of explosive projectile or air canister devices, including potato guns. Students are not allowed to work with hazardous or potentially explosive chemicals. **Senior Division** students are only allowed to conduct these types of projects under proper adult supervision when they have **exactly** followed the ISEF rules.
    c. Note GARSEF Display and Safety Rules.
3. **All projects require at a minimum teacher, student, and parent/guardian signatures prior to experimentation to ensure the safety of the student/subject and environment.**
4. Many projects will need additional pre-approval signatures. Any experiment conducted without having obtained the required approval signatures before experimentation begins, will be disqualified.
5. It is the responsibility of the student researcher(s) and the Teacher/Adult Sponsor to evaluate the project to determine if the research will require additional forms and/or review and approval

prior to experimentation, especially projects that include human participants, vertebrate animals, or potentially hazardous biological agents.

6. All **Senior Division** students will be required to complete a **Student Support Disclosure Form (2A)** in STEM Wizard (new 2027, ISEF). This form may be completed before or after experimentation.
7. All mentors must fill out a **Regulated Research Institutional/Industrial Setting Form (2C)** (**Senior Division**) AFTER experimentation is complete. For the **Junior Division**, students must upload a signed copy of the Form 2C JR: Middle School Mentor and Research Location Form from their mentor(s) explaining the assistance provided as an additional form in "Files and Forms" in STEM Wizard. All students with mentors must explain the mentorship assistance by answering the questions in the "Submissions for Judges Review" milestone in STEM Wizard. Disclosure must occur prior to the deadlines for those milestones in STEM Wizard.
8. Failure to disclose mentorship can result in disqualification. GARSEF reserves the right to revoke recognition of a project that did not disclose mentorship. All students, teachers, and mentors should review the Ethics statement in the GARSEF handbook.
9. It is the responsibility of the teacher, student, and parent/guardian to make sure that all required signatures for the project are completed on the paperwork prior to experimentation.
10. If a project is missing documentation deemed necessary by the regional or state SRC, the project may be disqualified and unable to compete.
11. All projects must adhere to the Ethics Statement above.
12. Projects must adhere to local, state and U.S. Federal laws, regulations and permitting conditions. In addition, projects conducted outside the U.S. must also adhere to the laws of the country and jurisdiction in which the project was performed.
13. The use of non-animal research methods and the use of alternatives to animal research are strongly encouraged and must be explored before conducting a vertebrate animal project.
14. Introduction or disposal of non-native and/or invasive species (e.g. insects, plants, invertebrates, vertebrates), pathogens, toxic chemicals or foreign substances into the environment is prohibited. It is recommended that students reference their local, state or national regulations and quarantine lists.
15. Scientist in Training (SIT): ISEF and GARSEF rules exist to ensure projects are conducted safely (for the student researchers, their participants and the environment) and ethically. We recognize that some students might not have had proper guidance and missed some required documentation; still they worked hard and had a positive experience. In order to encourage them to continue their STEM explorations, some disqualified projects might be permitted to participate in the Scientist In Training (SIT) program IF parental and teacher approval was obtained prior to experimentation AND the projects were conducted safely. This decision is at the discretion of the Fair Director in consultation with the SRC.

    SIT projects will be judged with their peers but cannot advance to other fairs and therefore are not eligible for 1st-3rd category places.

16. Plagiarism Reports: Teachers for **Senior Division** projects are required to submit plagiarism reports for abstracts and research plans for those projects by January 21, 2027. Information on how to submit the plagiarism reports will be sent to teachers in January. **Senior Division** students are required to complete the Submissions for Judges Review milestone in STEM Wizard by February 5, 2027. **Any Senior Division projects missing one or both of these items will be disqualified but allowed to participate at GARSEF as a Scientist In Training (SIT) only.**
17. **Jr/Sr Division Schools must make sure all students advancing to the regional fair have met all milestones due in STEM Wizard on or before January 21, 2027**. This includes checking Files and Forms paperwork. Students not advancing or with incomplete milestones need to be deactivated by the deadline.
18. **Junior Division** schools are required to provide (1) Teacher as a hall monitor during middle school judging, for every (10) projects the school sends.
19. **The number of projects allowed by each school is 60 projects.**
20. **Fees** - The entry fee is $25 per project. School invoices with instructions on how to pay will be e-mailed after the fair. Schools will be charged for every project registered on January 21, 2027, so please deactivate projects not advancing.



Roles & Responsibilities of Students & Adults

The Student Researcher(s)

The student researcher is responsible for all aspects of the research project, including enlisting the aid of any required supervisory adults (Adult Sponsor/Teacher, Qualified Scientist, etc.), obtaining necessary approvals (SRC, IRB, etc.), following the Rules & Guidelines of GARSEF, and performing the experimentation, engineering, data analysis, etc. Scientific fraud and misconduct are not condoned at any level of research or competition. This includes plagiarism, forgery, use or presentation of other researcher's work as one's own, and fabrication of data. Fraudulent projects will fail to qualify for competition. GARSEF reserves the right to revoke recognition of a project subsequently found to have been fraudulent.

The Adult Sponsor (Teacher)

The Adult Sponsor is usually the student's teacher or science fair club sponsor. This is the school representative and not the mentor from the RRI or other adult serving in a mentor capacity. This individual must have a solid background in science and should have close contact with the student during the course of the project. The Adult Sponsor is responsible for ensuring the student's research is eligible for entry in GARSEF.

Qualified Scientist

A Qualified Scientist should have earned a doctoral/professional degree in a scientific discipline that relates to the student's area of research. Alternatively, the SRC may consider an individual with extensive experience and expertise in the student's area of research as a Qualified Scientist. The Qualified Scientist must be thoroughly familiar with local, state, and federal regulations that govern the student's area of research.

Direct Supervisor

The Direct Supervisor is an adult who is directly responsible for overseeing student experimentation. The Direct Supervisor need not have an advanced degree, but must be thoroughly familiar with the student's project, and must be trained in the student's area of research. The Adult Sponsor may act as the Direct Supervisor.

Mentorship

Teachers and parents/guardians often support student research. But sometimes students seek an additional person -- a mentor -- who is also involved in directly supporting the student because of their expertise or experience in the field of work related to the research.

Mentors may be paid, unpaid, or provide the student(s) with an internship (paid or unpaid). Mentors may assist the student(s) through the science fair paperwork process, provide a space to work (e.g., access to a science lab), respond to science questions about the project, or help the student(s) meet experts in the field of their project.

Mentorship is not limited to work done in a lab or industry setting only. It can be done virtually, via phone, via e-mail, and/or in person by individuals or through a service that charges for science fair assistance.

It is the student's responsibility to come up with the project idea, plan the experiment or engineering design, perform the research or create the product, write the report, and create the display. As long as the student follows these guidelines, mentorship is allowed but must be fully disclosed. Modified from 4-H Canada.

Local/School Scientific Review Committee (SRC)

The Scientific Review Committee (SRC) is responsible for evaluation of student research plans, paperwork, and exhibits for compliance with the rules, applicable laws and regulations. Most proposed research projects involving vertebrate animals and/or potentially hazardous biological agents must be reviewed and approved by the SRC BEFORE experimentation. An SRC must consist of a minimum of three persons, including the following:

- a biomedical scientist with an earned graduate degree
- an educator,
- at least one additional member.

To avoid conflict of interest, no Adult Sponsor, parent or other relative of the student, the Qualified Scientist, or Direct Supervisor who oversees the project may serve on the SRC reviewing that project.

Institutional Review Board (IRB)

An Institutional Review Board (IRB), is a committee that must evaluate the potential physical and/or psychological risk of research involving humans. All proposed human research must be reviewed and approved by an IRB before experimentation begins. This includes review of any surveys or questionnaires to be used in a project.

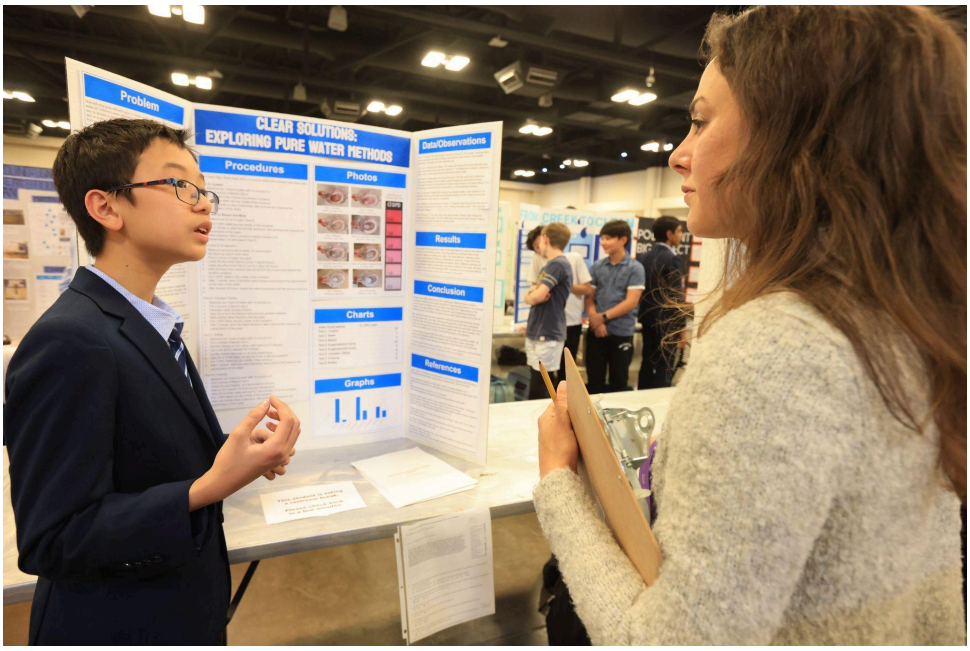
Federal regulations require local community involvement. Therefore, it is advisable that an IRB be established at the school level to evaluate human research projects. An IRB must consist of a minimum of three members including the following:

- an educator
- a school administrator (preferably principal or vice principal)
- a medical or mental health professional.

To avoid conflict of interest, no Adult Sponsor, parent or other relative of the student, the Qualified Scientist, or Direct Supervisor who oversees the project may serve on the IRB reviewing that project. Students who work at a regulated research institution must get approval from that institution's IRB prior to experimentation. The school IRB does not have jurisdiction over the regulated research institution.

GARSEF Scientific Review Committee (SRC)

The GARSEF Scientific Review Committee (SRC) is a group of qualified individuals responsible for evaluation of student research plans, paperwork, and exhibits for compliance with the rules, applicable laws and regulations. ALL projects must be reviewed and approved by the GARSEF SRC after experimentation and before competition in GARSEF.





What's New in 2027

New for 2027: GARSEF

- **Dates:**
  - All Jr/Sr Division students must complete their **STEM Wizard Account Creation** (complete Milestones 1 & 2 - Student and Project Information) **by October 14, 2026**.
  - **Files and Forms** should be complete, including signatures, **by November 18, 2026**
    - The *pre-approval* paperwork must be signed BEFORE experimentation.
    - Teachers are responsible for checking the paperwork to make sure it is complete before experimentation starts. The regional SRC will not review paperwork until after January 21, 2027, however, at that time signature dates will be checked and projects that are missing the signatures required prior to experimentation will be disqualified.
  - **Exceptions include:**
    - Form 2A (required for ALL **Senior Division**) may be completed before or after experimentation.
    - Form 2C JR (**Junior Division**, if required) and ISEF Forms 2C and 7 (**Senior Division**, if required) are to be signed AFTER experimentation.
    - Abstract - completed AFTER experimentation.
  - **ALL forms are due by January 21, 2027 at 5:00p.m.**
- **Junior/Senior Pre-Registration Form** required for **Junior Division** and **Senior Division schools** to confirm an estimated number of projects and verify paperwork completion. School Pre-Registration Form Submission: **January 8, 2027**.
- **Categories**: Computational Biology and Bioinformatics (CBIO) and Biomedical Engineering (ENBM) for **Junior** and **Senior Divisions**. (ISEF Category and Subcategory descriptions)
- **Senior Division Participation Agreement** will now be completed in STEM Wizard.
- **GARSEF Merchandise** will be available for pre-order purchase at the end of January.

New for 2027: ISEF Modifications

All Projects:

- **Mentorship disclosure:** All students are required to disclose any support they may have had and whether they received paid or unpaid mentorship.
  - **Junior Division**: a completed and signed copy of Form 2C JR: Middle School Mentor and Research Location Form must be uploaded as an additional file in "Files and Forms" in STEM Wizard. See the guiding arrows document for instructions.
  - **Senior Division:** Students who worked with mentors, either virtually or in person, or worked at a research location other than school or home, are required to submit **ISEF Form 2C**.
- **Artificial Intelligence (AI)** may be used as a resource but must be cited and given proper acknowledgment. A student is expected to do independent work and all materials presented must be in the researcher's own words. A student may not use generative AI to write the research plan, abstract, poster or to create citations (it is known to hallucinate and falsify references). See ISEF Guidelines for AI Use.

Human Participant Rules:

- Students are prohibited from disclosing research data from their study and/or from providing advice, diagnostic or medical information to participants ~~without direct supervision and involvement of a medical professional~~.
- For studies involving minors, if the study includes a survey, the survey must be attached to the consent form as part of the written parental permission process and parental permission obtained prior to the minor accessing the survey.
- Studies that involve recruitment and interaction with human participants online or via the internet are allowed if they adhere to all of the human participant rules above regarding consent processes and restrictions, including obtaining written parental permission for studies involving minors. This written parental permission must include a copy of the survey and be obtained prior to a minor accessing the online survey. In order to protect the confidentiality of the participants, it is extremely important that IP addresses, as well as the data provided, be safeguarded.

Vertebrate Animal Rules:

- Student researchers are prohibited from performing euthanasia. Clarification has been added for euthanasia for agricultural/aquacultural projects raised for food. See "After Experimentation/Euthanasia" section.

Potentially Hazardous Biological Agents (PHBA) Rules:

- Clarification of prion rule: All studies involving the use of prions or commercially available purified prion-like proteins are prohibited. This includes studies working with amyloid-beta (Ab), tau, alpha-synuclein, transactive response DNA-binding protein of 43kDa, amyloid fibrils, and Huntingtin protein. Studies involving plasmids that contain genes encoding prion-like proteins are also prohibited.
- Students are prohibited from collecting water samples during a Harmful Algal Bloom (HAB). Qualified personnel may collect the water samples and provide the student with the samples for testing. Testing of water collected during an HAB must be done in a BSL-2 lab, under BSL-2 conditions.
- Studies involving animal models that have been bred to express prion-like proteins, including but not limited to *C. elegans* and *Drosophila*, are permissible in a BSL-1 laboratory, if the studies are behavioral only and do not involve lysing or dissection of cells or purification of proteins. Work involving the lysis of cells or cell lines and/or purification of prion-like proteins must be conducted in a BSL-2 laboratory, under BSL-2 conditions.

  Under Exempt Studies:
- Studies involving Lactobacillus, Bacillus thuringiensis, nitrogen-fixing bacteria (excluding cyanobacteria), oil-eating bacteria, and algae-eating bacteria introduced into their natural environment (not exempt if cultured in a petri dish environment).

Tissue and Body Fluid Rules:

Exempt Tissue Clarifications:

- Plant and **vertebrate** ~~non-primate~~ BSL1 established cell lines and tissue culture collections (e.g., obtained from the American Type CultureCollection). The source and/or catalog number of the

cultures must be identified in the Research Plan and on ~~forms 6A and 6B~~ **Form 3**.

- Collection and/or study without culturing of eggs, pasteurized milk or fresh/frozen meat and meat by-products obtained from food stores, restaurants, or packing houses.

Hazardous Chemicals, Activities, or Devices Rules:

- Projects involving chemicals that are listed as carcinogenic, teratogenic, or reproductive system damaging on the SDS must be conducted at an RRI or in a restricted access fume hood outside of the regular classroom (i.e. school lab). The qualified scientist and direct supervisor must have training in the usage, safe handling, and disposal of the chemicals.
- Under DEA Controlled Substances, #2 was edited to remove marijuana, as its federal designation changed: All studies using DEA Schedule 1 substances ~~(including marijuana)~~ must have the research protocol approved by DEA before research begins. Schedule 2, 3 and 4 substances do not require protocol approval by DEA.

FORMS:

- Form headers were edited for clarity and consistency
- **Student Support Disclosure Form (2A)** – NEW
  - This is a new form that is required for all projects. It can be filled out before or after experimentation by the finalist.
- **Qualified Scientist Form (2B)**
  - Renumbered to be 2B instead of Form 2
  - Added question about scientist's role in student's research: Please describe your anticipated role in this project and the duration of your support.
- **Regulated Research Institutional/Industrial Setting Form (2C)**
  - Renumbered to be 2C instead of 1C
  - Added question: What was the duration of your support of this student project?
- **Human and Vertebrate Animal Tissue Form (6B)**
  - Checkboxes were added to question 1 to provide more tissue options.

ISEF Rules and Guidelines Resources – Please review:

- 2027 Rules and Guidelines (HTML) - user friendly
- 2027 Rules and Guidelines (PDF) - printable
- Companion Guide to ISEF Rules
- 2027 Rules Modifications - Final Changes
- 2027 Forms Only (PDF)
- 2027 Display & Safety Rules (HTML)
- Display & Safety Graphic Credit Guidance
- Generative Use AI Table
- Field Work Safety Plan
- ISEF Guidelines for Biosafety Level 1 (BSL-1)
- ISEF Guidelines for Biosafety Level 2 (BSL-2)

Registration Information

STEM Wizard

All Junior and Senior Division school and student registration will be done through **STEM Wizard**. Paper forms will not be accepted. Student STEM Wizard accounts should be created and the research plan approved by the adult sponsor/teacher, SRC (if required), and IRB (if required) prior to the student beginning their research. STEM Wizard has an embedded rules wizard that will determine what forms students need to fill out for their project (Senior Division only). It is up to the student and adult sponsor/teacher to make sure that all paperwork is filled out properly, including dates (**start date must be AFTER approval signatures**). Students must have parental/guardian approval in STEM Wizard prior to the start of experimentation. STEM Wizard has milestones with deadlines that students will need to meet in order to participate. If a student fails to meet a deadline, their account may be deactivated, and they will not be able to compete.

STEM Wizard Training Materials

- Teacher STEM Wizard Guide
- Student STEM Wizard Guide
- STEM Wizard Help Page

Registration Steps

STEM Wizard Registration typically opens after the Teacher Orientation in early September.

1. **School Registration**:
    a. If your school has participated in the past, it should be registered in STEM Wizard.
    b. If your school is not registered in STEM Wizard, please have your school fair administrator contact JRSRstaff@austinscience.org.
2. **Teacher/Adult Sponsor Registration**:
    a. Once your school is registered in STEM Wizard, all teachers with participating students need to register individually. Each individual teacher is considered the Adult Sponsor for select students from their school.
3. **Secondary Teacher/Campus Coordinator Registration**:
    a. The Secondary Teacher/Campus Coordinator in STEM Wizard is able to view all students that choose them as the secondary teacher. This allows for one adult at a school/district to view all projects for the school or district.
        - Option 1: For each school or school district with multiple teachers, choose a teacher or administrator to act as the secondary teacher for the school. That teacher/administrator should add "(Campus Coordinator)" after their name when they register for an account. All students for that school or school district should

select that teacher or administrator as their secondary teacher. If the Campus Coordinator also serves as the teacher for some students, they may want to register twice and use a different email address for the secondary teacher login to make it easier to view all students vs. the teacher's own students.

- Option 2: If a secondary teacher/campus coordinator is not needed (ex. Only one teacher/adult sponsor at the school with a small number of projects), there will be a generic "Campus *Coordinator" listed that can be chosen instead of a teacher creating a second account.

4. **Student Account Creation**:
   a. Begins once all teachers are registered.
      - Students who have previously participated in the Junior or Senior Division of GARSEF should use the Student Login and the previous year's username and password.
      - Students who have not previously participated in the Junior or Senior Division of GARSEF should start with Student Registration.
   b. ALL students must complete the first two milestones in STEM Wizard (Project + Student Information) by **October 14, 2026**
      - We recommend using the STEM Wizard Account Creation Worksheet to help students gather information needed for registration.
   c. Students competing as a team will each begin STEM Wizard registration in their individual accounts and choose 'team' to register as a team. Once registration is started as a team or individual, it cannot be changed later. If students register as a team, all team members are expected to participate in-person at GARSEF.
5. **Project Registration and Paperwork Completion**:
   a. All students should complete and submit their required files and forms in the Files and Forms Milestone by **November 18, 2026**, including pre-approval signatures.
      - These forms are required to be completed prior to experimentation. Forms are intended as guidelines; therefore, reviewing and following all ISEF rules is required.
      - It is the responsibility of the teacher, student, and parent/guardian to make sure that all required signatures for the project are completed on the paperwork prior to experimentation.
      - Students must send links to obtain required approval signatures after completing their portion of the paperwork in SW.
      - Exceptions:
        - Form 2A (before or after experimentation) - **Senior Division** only
        - Form 2C JR (**Junior Division**, if required) and ISEF Forms 2C, and/or Form 7 (**Senior Division**, if required) are submitted after experimentation is complete.
   b. The Abstract (in Files and Forms) and an Additional Information milestone will be added to STEM Wizard **January 4, 2027.** These must be completed after experimentation and before **January 15, 2027**. The Files and Forms milestone deadline will be updated in January due to the addition of the abstract. (Previously these were released with the other registration milestones, and students were completing them too early in the process.)

   c. Sample Forms can be found in the Project Forms section of the GARSEF Handbook.
6. **Junior/Senior School Pre-Registration Form:**
   a. Required for **Junior Division** and **Senior Division** schools to confirm an estimated number of projects and verify paperwork completion. Submission: **January 8, 2027**.
7. Project Registration Submission **Deadline**:
   a. All registration milestones must be completed by the dates listed in STEMWizard; all documentation must be submitted by the deadline of **January 21, 2027.**
   b. Teachers need to confirm which students are advancing to the regional fair and deactivate those students who are not advancing.
   c. All students advancing to the regional fair must have completed ALL MILESTONES in STEM Wizard by the deadline or the student will be deactivated in STEM Wizard and unable to compete.
8. Final Student Milestone:
   a. Students must complete the final milestone - Submissions for Judges Review - once the project has passed regional SRC approval. This is due by **February 5, 2027 at 5:00 p.m**. **Senior Division** projects without virtual project boards will not be eligible for advancement to TXSEF or ISEF.
9. No late entries will be allowed.



Project Categories - GARSEF

Many projects could easily fit into multiple categories. We highly recommend that you review the entire listing of the categories before carefully choosing the category that most accurately describes your project. Please note that ENBM is a new category at GARSEF for both divisions for 2027 and CBIO was added to the Junior Division this year. ISEF Category description

Animal Sciences (ANIM)
- Agricultural Animal Science
- Animal Behavior
- Cellular Studies
- Development
- Ecology
- Genetics
- Nutrition and Growth
- Physiology
- Systematics & Evolution

Behavioral and Social Sciences (BEHA)
- Behavioral Neuroscience
- Development
- Cognitive Psychology
- Sociology and Anthropology

Biochemistry (BCHM)
- Analytical Biochemistry
- General Biochemistry
- Medicinal Biochemistry
- Structural Biochemistry

Biomedical and Health Sciences (BMED)
- Cell, Organ, and Systems Physiology
- Genetics and Molecular Biology of Disease
- Immunology
- Nutrition and Natural Products
- Pathophysiology

Biomedical Engineering (ENBM) - NEW 2027!
- Biomaterials and Regenerative Medicine
- Biomechanics
- Biomedical Devices
- Biomedical Sensors and Imaging
- Cell and Tissue Engineering
- Synthetic Biology

Cellular and Molecular Biology (CELL)
- Cell Physiology
- Cellular Immunology
- Genetics
- Molecular Biology
- Neurobiology

Chemistry (CHEM)
- Analytical Chemistry
- Computational Chemistry
- Environmental Chemistry
- Organic/Inorganic Chemistry
- Materials Chemistry
- Physical Chemistry

Computational Biology and Bioinformatics (CBIO) - NEW 2027! - both divisions
- Computational Biomodelling
- Computational Epidemiology
- Computational Evolutionary Biology
- Computational Neuroscience
- Computational Pharmacology
- Genomics

Earth and Environmental Sciences (EAEV)
- Atmospheric Science
- Climate Science
- Environmental Effects on Ecosystems
- Geosciences
- Water Science

Embedded Systems (EBED)
- System Hardware
- Circuits
- Internet of Things
- Microcontrollers
- Networking/Communications
- Optics
- Sensors
- Signal Processing
- Robotic Mechanical Design

Energy: Sustainable Materials and Design (EGSD)
- Biological Process and Design
- Solar Process, Materials, and Design
- Energy Storage
- Wind and Water Movement Power Generation
- Hydrogen Generation and Storage
- Thermal Generation and Design
- Triboelectricity and Electrolysis

Engineering Technology: Statics and Dynamics (ETSD)
- Aerospace and Aeronautical Engineering
- Civil Engineering
- Computational Mechanics
- Control Theory
- Electrical Engineering
- Ground Vehicle Systems
- Industrial Engineering-Processing
- Mechanical Engineering
- Naval Systems
- Structural Engineering

Environmental Engineering (ENEV)
- Bioremediation
- Land Reclamation
- Pollution Control
- Recycling and Waste Management
- Water Resources Management

Materials Science (MATS)
- Biomaterials
- Ceramic and Glasses
- Composite Materials
- Computation and Theory
- Electronic, Optical, and Magnetic Materials
- Nanomaterials
- Polymers

Mathematics (MATH)
- Algebra
- Combinatorics, Graph Theory, and Game Theory
- Geometry and Topology
- Mathematical Analysis
- Number Theory
- Probability and Statistics

Microbiology (MCRO)
- Antimicrobials and Antibiotics
- Applied Microbiology
- Bacteriology
- Environmental Microbiology
- Microbial Genetics
- Virology

Physics and Astronomy (PHYS)
- Atomic, Molecular, and Optical Physics
- Astronomy and Cosmology
- Biological Physics
- Condensed Matter and Materials
- Mechanics
- Nuclear and Particle Physics
- Theoretical, Computational, and Quantum Physics

Plant Sciences (PLNT)
- Agriculture and Agronomy
- Ecology
- Genetics and Breeding
- Growth and Development
- Pathology
- Plant Physiology
- Systematics and Evolution

Software Design (SFTD)
- Algorithms
- Cybersecurity
- Databases
- Human/Machine Interface
- Languages and Operating Systems
- Mobile Apps
- Robotics Artificial Intelligence/Cognitive Systems
- Machine Learning

Translational Medical Sciences (aka Disease Studies) (TMED)
- Disease Detection and Diagnosis
- Disease Prevention
- Disease Treatment and Therapies
- Drug Identification and Testing
- Pre-Clinical Studies

Guidelines for the Use of AI in Science Fair Projects

At GARSEF we recognize the growing interest in utilizing Artificial Intelligence (AI) technology, including Large Language Models (LLMs), Machine Learning (ML) and Generative AI for research projects. However, with great power comes great responsibility. As such, we provide guidelines for responsibly engaging with AI technologies to maintain project integrity and uphold ethical standards.

- **Student Ownership:** AI tools may be used to support student learning, not replace it. All projects submitted to GARSEF must be the student's original work. ISEF added this statement about AI use to the Eligibility/Limitations section of the rulebook. "**Artificial Intelligence (AI) may be used as a resource but must be cited and given proper acknowledgment. A student is expected to do independent work and all materials presented must be in the researcher's own words. A student may not use generative AI to write the research plan, abstract, poster or to create citations (it is known to hallucinate and falsify references).**" Please note the last part in particular. Students may not use AI to write their research plan, abstract, paper, or poster. AI may only be used as a resource and must be cited. While generative AI tools are allowed, their use is optional, not mandatory.
- **Purposeful Engagement:** Students can use AI tools as aids for exploring topics, searching for information, clarifying complex texts, or checking grammar. However, students are strongly encouraged to read primary and secondary sources, analyze evidence, and make independent choices in their writing and presentations.
- **Adult Sponsor Involvement:** Students are highly encouraged to collaborate with their adult sponsors to demonstrate genuine engagement with their projects and keep them apprised of how and when they use AI.

Understanding AI and LLMs

- LLMs like Chat GPT generate human-like text based on input. They operate with a knowledge cutoff (i.e. any new information, events, or developments after the tool was trained will not be accessible) and therefore may lack up-to-date information. They can provide general information but might not always be accurate or context-aware.
- When using AI, avoid sharing personal details. Treat AI as a tool, not a confidant.

Citation and Verification

- Verify AI-generated information from reliable sources. You may use AI-generated information as a starting point for research.
- Ask AI for its sources and, if applicable, cite them as described below.
- Properly cite generative AI as references.

Addressing Bias

- AI may inherit biases from their training data. Critically assess AI-generated content for potential biases.
- Address identified biases in your project and work to mitigate any bias wherever possible.

Ethical Considerations

- Think about the ethical implications of using AI in your research. Uphold ethical principles in your work and discussions involving AI.
- Employ AI only for legitimate purposes. Avoid generating false information, deception, or harm.
- Use AI tools as a supplement but rely on your independent analysis and research.
- Do not claim AI-generated essays as your own original work. Ethical concerns arise when the AI program produces essays that are claimed to be the original work of a person.
- Remember that AI is a tool to enhance your research, not a replacement for critical thinking and creativity.

AI Limitations

- LLMs such as ChatGPT may not always understand complex or context-specific questions.
- To receive accurate responses, start with specific, clear inquiries.
- Refine your questions to target the information you need and be patient and persistent in refining until you obtain accurate answers.
- Remember "garbage in = garbage out."

Experimentation and Documentation

- Document your interactions with AI, including the questions you ask and the responses you receive. **GARSEF requires a copy of the transcript when utilizing ChatGPT or similar AI interface.** The transcript should include the name of the AI tool used, the date used, and the input and output of all inquiries. This must be added as an additional file in STEM Wizard and available at the fair for judges to review.
- Maintain a logbook to ensure transparency in your research process.
- Remember, AI is a powerful tool, but it's essential to use it responsibly and ethically. Good luck with your GARSEF project!

Additional Resources:

AI vs. Machine Learning vs. Deep Learning vs. Neural Networks: What's the difference?
Video: How Large Language Models Work
Harvard Business School: Student Use Cases for AI
ChatGPT: An Introduction for Educators
Statement from the International Baccalaureate about Artificial Intelligence in Education
Ethical AI for Teaching and Learning
Shedding light on AI Bias with Real World Examples
How to Cite AI Use

AI Tools:

- Chat GPT
- Khanmigo
- Gemini
- Copilot
- Claude

AI and Your Project: Acceptable Use

AI Use and Your Project		
Research Assistance AI may help you gather background information about your topic quickly. This may aid you in developing a strong knowledge base.	**Idea Generation** AI may assist students in brainstorming project ideas and suggesting research questions, hypotheses, or experimental design.	**Data Analysis** The use of AI may help guide students on data analysis techniques, statistical tests, or software tools for processing and interpreting results.
Experimental Procedure AI can assist in offering suggestions to improve accuracy, control variables, and ensure safety, but it can not write the research plan.	**Explanation and Clarification** Students can ask AI to explain complex scientific concepts, theories, or equations related to their projects, aiding their understanding and communication of the topic.	**Source Recommendation** AI can provide suggestions for credible sources, articles, books, or research papers. **The student is expected to review the sources and create their own bibliography.**
Figure Creation Students can ask for guidance on creating effective visual representations of their data, such as graphs, charts, or diagrams, to enhance the presentation of their results. All figures must be properly cited including the method used to create student images/figures.	**Ethical Considerations** AI can help students think through the ethical aspects of their projects, including considerations of human or animal subjects, environmental impact, and data privacy.	**Presentation and Communication** Students can seek tips on creating engaging project presentations, posters, or oral explanations for the science fair judges and attendees. However, students can not use AI to write the presentation for them.

The information here has been adapted from the following sources: SEFH, DMRSEF, College Board, and BRSF.

See ISEF Guidelines for AI Use to determine whether you should or should not use AI.

Project Display

Maximum Size of Project

Depth (front to back): 15 inches or 38 cm - **Junior Division**
30 inches or 76 cm - **Senior Division**
Width (side to side): 48 inches or 122 cm
Height (floor to top): 95 inches or 240 cm **(changed for 2025)**

- All students will need a physical project board for display.
    - Note: A virtual project board will also be required for judges to preview the projects. Students should use the project board template for their virtual project boards.
- All project materials and board support mechanisms must fit within the project dimensions.
- All project boards will be expected to stand on their own or with a stand that fits within the display dimensions.
- Remember to take the table height into account when determining the height of the project. GARSEF-provided tables will not exceed a height of 36 inches (91 cm). Therefore the board should be no taller than 60". This means that two boards on top of each other will not fit.

Display & Safety

No objects other than boards, binders, laptops/tablets and ISEF paperwork requirements are allowed in the exhibit hall. Only paper and photos should be attached to the project board. Anything else will be removed. This means demonstration items are not allowed.

Board displays must follow all ISEF rules. The following items are prohibited in the exhibit hall:.

- Images of animals or people in surgical techniques or necropsies or animals not in their natural habitat
- Ribbons, medals, and awards won at previous fairs
- Laser pointers
- Open containers of food and beverages

Abstract

The official abstract must be displayed vertically at the booth in an acrylic frame or taped to the edge of the table.. Do not add an abstract section to the project board. Only the official abstract (with the SRC signature) is allowed to be displayed.

Display Content for Projects Conducted at a Research Institution

The display must reflect only the work conducted by the finalist. Minimal reference to mentor's or other researcher's work must only reflect background information or be used to clarify differences between finalist's and others' work. Mentors may be added to the acknowledgement section. Do not include logos or the name of the research institution on the board. Senior Division projects that have Form 2C must also display the form(s) at the booth vertically.

Continuation Projects

If a study is a continuation project, information from the previous years' project should be limited to summative conclusionary data but not include raw data or images of prior engineered designs. Senior Division Continuation Projects must display Form 7 at the booth vertically.

Self Promotion

Students are not allowed to self-promote. No items may be handed out to the judges. References to patents or to patents pending are not allowed. Research papers with the student as an author can be included in the student binder, but should not be out on display.

Photograph/Image Display Requirements

Individual citations are required for every image/photo/chart/graph on the project board (including student created images). A citation must be provided alongside the graphic or in a vertically, numbered displayed reference list.

- Images created by the student(s) must include the application used to create the image and the year the image was created. Example - "Image created by student researcher(s) using Canva, 2027." See ISEF D&S Graphic Credit Guidance for additional examples.
- ALL graphics not created by the student(s) MUST BE properly cited individually (APA format is preferred). Graphics obtained via the Internet must have URL provided (digital object identifiers are acceptable in place of long URLs). This applies even if the license under which the graphic was obtained does not require credit or citation.

Display of photographs of people other than that of the student researcher must have a photo release signed by the subject and, if under 18 years of age, also by the guardian of the subject. Sample consent text: "I consent to the use of visual images (photos, videos, etc.) involving my participation/my child's participation in this research." (These forms must be available upon request, but shall not be displayed.)

Photos of brand logos are not allowed. For projects in which the student compared brands, the brand names may not be used. Students can use Brand A vs. Brand B.



Message from the GARSEF Scientific Review Committee

Prior to attempting to complete any documentation for entry to GARSEF, we strongly recommend that students communicate with mentors and/or adult sponsors to firmly grasp the extent of the research and the necessary documentation that GARSEF requires for the student's project. Students, mentors, and teachers are required to review all ISEF rules.

Top GARSEF Paperwork Problems to Avoid: Link to document

1. Missing required pre-approval signatures. Signatures must be obtained BEFORE the start of experimentation. Typed names will not be accepted as signatures.
    a. **ALL Projects: Adult Sponsor/Teacher, Student, AND Parent/Guardian.**
    b. **Some Projects:** IRB, SRC, Qualified Scientist, and/or Direct Supervisor
2. Missing, incomplete, or incorrect paperwork (See ISEF Forms and Rules Quick Reference - **Senior Division;** See MS Form Guidance for **Junior Division**)
    a. The project must include all required forms with the appropriate signatures needed for the specific project.
    b. Parents, relatives, the adult sponsor (teacher), qualified scientist, or direct supervisor of the student may not sign as SRC or IRB members to avoid a conflict of interest.
3. Research Plan lacks sufficient details and fails to provide thorough information to support the documentation provided. A properly written research plan must include:
    a. A detailed list of materials including amounts. Include where you will purchase any bacteria or other potentially hazardous biological agents. If you will use E. coli k-12, make sure to list that as the material.
    b. A detailed research plan procedure - projects which cannot be assessed because the research plan is not sufficient will fail to qualify.
    c. Clear details about what the student will do when working in a research institution or as part of a larger project. The research plan must identify both the student's and the mentor's role in the project.
    d. Any additional documentation needed to understand the project including any surveys or tests for human subjects, last year's paperwork for continuation studies, etc.
4. Human Participants
    a. The student researcher is a human participant in their project if they are the subject of the experiment or a variable in the experiment. Examples: Student researcher becomes part of the experiment or tests their design - such as cranking a wheel, jumping, running, kicking a ball - or collecting their own identifiable data such as fingerprints.
        i. This requires Form 4 for the **Senior Division**.
        ii. For the **Junior Division**, signatures from the School Administrator AND a Psychologist, Medical Doctor, or Registered Nurse are required on the MS Safety and Consent Form. The only exception is if the researcher OR the adult sponsor is testing student designed software.
    b. If the student works at a regulated research institution, approval for the project needs to be from the institutional IRB, not from the school IRB. This is for ALL divisions.

5. Vertebrate Animals
    a. A veterinarian must be consulted and certify experiments that involve supplemental nutrition, administration of prescription drugs and/or activities that would not be ordinarily encountered in the animal's daily life.
    b. Students are not allowed to cause pain, distress, or death of animals in their study.
    c. Students who work at a regulated research institution will need to submit the IACUC approval for the project with a letter from the IACUC, stating the student was trained and allowed to work on the study.
    d. Tissue analysis projects are identified as vertebrate animal projects. If the student never comes in contact with live animals and only uses vertebrate animal tissues collected by someone else for the study, this is a tissue study (forms 6A and 6B for the **Senior Division** or Biomedical/Biological Scientist signature for **Junior Division**).
    e. Vertebrate Animal projects require Form 5A or 5B (RRI) for **Senior Division** and require a signature from the Veterinarian or Biomedical/Biological Scientist for **Junior Division** (depending on the type of project - see 5a).
6. Potentially Hazardous Biological Agents
    a. **Bacteria, mold, or other microorganisms can NOT be grown at home. This is an automatic disqualification.**
    b. Microorganisms must be grown in the appropriate BSL setting under supervision, following standard laboratory protocols.
    c. Students are only allowed to work with BSL-1 or BSL-2 organisms. BSL-2 projects may not be done in school labs. These projects must be done at a regulated research institution (RRI) and supervised by a qualified scientist (GARSEF rule beginning 2026).
    d. Unknown organisms cultured from the environment can be treated as BSL-1 only if the petri dishes are sealed shut and never reopened prior to proper disposal. Any project where the student cultures unknown bacteria from the environment and then opens the test tube or petri dish to subculture or analyze the sample is a BSL-2 project.
    e. Yeast, when cultured, requires Form 6A for **Senior Division** or Biomedical/Biological Scientist signature for **Junior Division** and must be done in a school lab or RRI.
7. Missing Risk Assessment Form 3 (**Senior Division only**)
    a. Must be completed for projects that involve chemicals, equipment, or other potential hazards.
    b. Must be completed for any project involving human testing of student-designed inventions, prototypes, or consumer products.
    c. Often missing, and often incomplete without description of safety precautions taken.
8. Mentorship and Research Location:
    a. Form 2C (**Senior Division**) must be filled out and signed by the mentor or the person who approved the student to work in their lab or business such as the person at HEB who gives the person the right to collect samples there or the research lab supervisor at the university where the person worked. It should NOT be filled out by the parent or teacher.
    b. For the **Junior Division**, any student working at a business or research institution or with a mentor will need a completed Form 2C JR: Middle School Mentor and Research Location Form. This needs to be uploaded as an additional file.

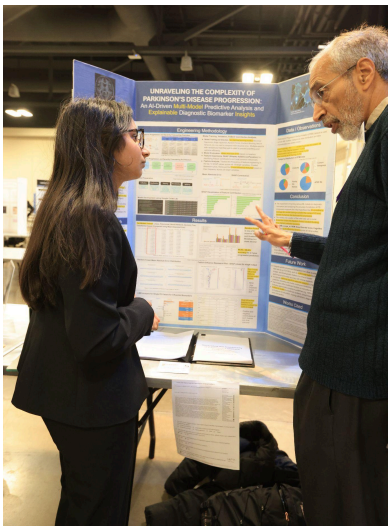
Judges and Volunteers

- Judges register in STEM Wizard. Judges are asked to attend an orientation (on-line in February 2027).
- Volunteers register through SignUp Genius.
- Each school should provide one judge ***and*** one volunteer for every 10 registered school projects.
- Middle Schools are required to provide (1) Teacher as a hall monitor during middle school judging, for every (10) projects the school sends.



Judging Criteria

The Judge Criteria Sheet is on our website. Comments from judges will be returned to the schools.





Fair Week Expectations



The entire event is held at the Palmer Events Center in Austin, TX:
900 Barton Springs Road, 78704
Parking is free to volunteers, judges, teachers, students, and parents during the fair.

Schedule

Detailed Junior and Senior Division Schedule for GARSEF 2027

Wednesday Check-in and Board Setup

All project boards should be checked in to the Palmer Events Center the day before the Fair. A teacher or school representative may bring all project boards and abstracts (the official abstract form from STEM Wizard Files and Forms) to the Center, or parents/students may bring the boards individually. Make sure all project boards have the full project number (Ex. CHEM-4325-JR-T) written in sharpie on the **back right corner** of the board. This is the location where the project will be in the exhibit hall. Students need to know their project numbers to find their boards. The project numbers will be available in STEM Wizard a week before the fair.
Check-in is a 3-step process:

- Check project board(s) in at the registration tables. Volunteers will check that project numbers are on the back of the board.
- Pass through Display and Safety to get the board(s), abstract(s), and any other required paperwork checked for rule violations (Display and Safety Rules). No objects other than boards, binders, laptops/tablets and project paperwork requirements are allowed in the exhibit hall. New for GARSEF 2025 - Boards can not be taller than 60" and can only have paper or photos on them.
- Set up the project board(s) at the assigned booth number(s). To find the booth location, first find the category location (first four letters of the project number). Then look for the number.
- Do not leave any electronics unattended. GARSEF is not responsible for stolen or lost items.

What Students can expect during judging

- Students and teachers should review the Judge Criteria Sheet and practice presentations before the fair.
- **Students should arrive 15 minutes prior to their judging period or earlier if they need to go through Display and Safety again.**
- **No food or drink is allowed in the Exhibit Hall.** Bathrooms and water stations are available inside the Exhibit Hall.
- If a student has an important question or a sudden need, find one of the dozens of volunteers positioned throughout the Exhibit Hall and ask for assistance.
- **Students should remain by their projects until they are dismissed**. This will be done by category. Students are encouraged to bring a book. If students need to use the restroom, they

should ask a volunteer for a note to leave by their project in case judges come by while the students are away from their project.

- **Students should be prepared to provide a brief summary of their project and answer questions from the judges**. Each project will have at least three judges. There may be more than that, including special award judges.
- In the **Senior Division**, some students may advance to Top Tier Judging, held in the afternoon. Selected students and their projects will be moved to a new area for this judging session before remaining students are released from the morning session. Students will have a short break to notify their teacher or parent and get something to eat prior to the next judging session.

What Teachers and Parents can expect during judging

- Parents and teachers can escort their students to the correct booth in the exhibit hall 15-20 minutes before judging begins. If you forgot the booth number, visit the Registration Table or Information Booth for assistance. The booth number can also be found in STEM Wizard. It is the project number. **Do not bring food or drink into the Exhibit Hall.**
- Make a plan for where to meet your student(s) after they finish with judging. You will not be allowed back in the Exhibit Hall while judging is in process.
- About ten minutes before Judging, parents and teachers will be asked to leave the Exhibit Hall. There are chairs in the Awards Hall (behind the airwall) as well as tables and chairs in the hallway along the side of the Exhibit Hall. Judging cannot begin until all parents and teachers leave the Exhibit Hall, with the exception of the Middle School Teachers who volunteer to be hall monitors.
- Once judging is finished, students are released by category and will go find their teacher or parent.

Awards and Award Ceremony

- During the Award Ceremony, Special Award and Category Award winners will be announced. Trophies, medals, and certificates will be handed out to students on stage. Special award items will be handed out off stage.
- School representatives should pick up student comment sheets after the award ceremony at the table to the right side of the stage. If the teacher will not be there, please identify another person to pick up the comment sheets to take to the school.
- Students, teachers, and families are encouraged to attend the Award Ceremony. If you cannot stay for the ceremony, please make sure another student or teacher picks up any awards for you. You can pick up your project board during the Public Viewing time or have a friend pick up the board as they leave the ceremony. Boards not picked up by 4:00 p.m. on Saturday will be discarded by Palmer Staff.
- Awards will also be listed on our website once the Ceremony is complete. If there is a missing award, please ask the teacher or sponsor to contact GARSEF staff.
- Judges' decisions are final.
- Photos will be uploaded to the web page about a week after the Event

Frequently Asked Questions

Why does the research plan have to be in the future tense?

The research plan indicates all the aspects of the research to be conducted and determines the necessary documentation that the student will need to conduct the research. This should be written and approved prior to experimentation. It is critical that it establishes the student's actual role in the research and the role of other individuals that might contribute to the project.

What is the difference between the GARSEF's SRC and an institution's SRC?

The GARSEF SRC uses the guidelines established by the ISEF SRC to determine if the project qualifies for GARSEF. Meanwhile, an institution's SRC typically refers to the "body" that oversees projects conducted at that particular research institution. Procedures approved by institutional SRC can still conflict with ISEF SRC rules—for example those involving pain tolerance or the death of animals. Thus, it is very important to make mentors aware of ISEF/GARSEF rules and regulations when planning research.

Can the GARSEF SRC approve a project before it starts or before the SRC submission deadline?

The GARSEF SRC does not officially pre-approve projects. However, if you have a question about the documentation needed for a project, we can provide rule guidance in advance. All projects must be approved by the GARSEF SRC after they are conducted and this must occur prior to GARSEF presentation.

Can the GARSEF SRC disqualify a project that has been approved by an institution's SRC?

Yes, since it is possible that a project can be approved by an institution with rules differing from those made by ISEF and GARSEF which are focused on high school researchers and thus have stricter rules.

Should schools form their own IRB committees?

Yes, schools should form their own IRB unless the project was conducted at a Regulated Research Institution with its own IRB, ensuring they follow the rules and regulations provided by ISEF.

When should a project be classified as a continuation project?

A continuation project is one in which the current project is based on what the student learned from their research in one or more previous years. The student must document what has changed from any previous year's work. A repetition of the previous project is not an acceptable continuation. Only the current year's project will be judged.

Does ISEF limit the time or length of a project?

Yes, all projects must be completed within one year and may not start before January of the year preceding the competition year.

Once I have completed my registration, can I change categories?

No, once student project registration closes in January, no category changes are allowed unless they are made by GARSEF due to low category numbers.

If I decide to drop-out of GARSEF after registration closes in January, will my school still be charged the registration fee?

Yes. Registration fees will still be charged for every project not deactivated by the project submission deadline in January.

Are GARSEF Rules the same as ISEF Rules?

GARSEF rules are guided by ISEF rules, however they can differ based on our local regulations and needs. GARSEF rules supersede ISEF rules.



GARSEF
GREATER AUSTIN REGIONAL SCIENCE AND ENGINEERING FAIR
A Program of the Austin Science Education Foundation

GARSEF Website

www.austinscience.org.

Our website contains:

- Junior/Senior Divisions
  - Teacher Orientation
  - Teacher Resources
  - Student Resources
  - STEM Wizard Help
  - Parent/Guardian Information
  - Virtual Exhibit Hall
  - Awards
  - Beyond GARSEF
- Elementary
  - Teacher Orientation
  - Resources
  - School Registration
  - Awards
- Parent/Guardian Information
- Get Involved
  - Judge
  - Volunteer
  - Donate
- Corporate Sponsors
- ASEF
  - Board
  - History



APPENDIX: Project Forms

Project Forms

All forms need to be filled out in STEM Wizard as part of the Files and Forms milestone. There are different forms for the Junior and Senior Divisions. The following pages show examples of the forms with guiding arrows showing how to fill out the forms.

For both divisions, all signatures must be actual signatures or Adobe e-signatures. **Typed names will not be accepted in place of signatures.**

Please review the sample documents and carefully check all paperwork prior to submitting to the Regional SRC.

Sample Junior Division Forms

Sample Texas MS Safety and Consent Form with Guiding Arrows
Sample Form 2C JR: Middle School Mentor and Research Location Form with Guiding Arrows

Sample Senior Division Forms (ISEF)

All ISEF Forms
ISEF Forms with Guiding Arrows:

- Checklist for Adult Sponsor (1) - required for all students
- Student Checklist (1A) - required for all students
- Research Plan/Project Addendum Instructions - required for all students
- Approval Form (1B) required for all students
- Student Support Disclosure Form (2A) - required for all students
- Qualified Scientist Form (2B)
- Regulated Research Institutional/Industrial Setting Form (2C) (and mentor disclosure)
- Risk Assessment Form (3)
- Human Participants Form (4)
- Human Informed Consent Form
- Vertebrate Animal Form (5A)
- Vertebrate Animal Form (5B)
- Potentially Hazardous Biological Agents Risk Assessment Form (6A)
- Human and Vertebrate Animal Tissue Form (6B)
- Continuation/Research Progression Projects Form (7)

Signatures for STEM Wizard Forms

All signatures throughout the documents (students, teachers and supervisors) must be in signature format. Typed signatures, like the one shown on the right, will not be accepted unless they can be validated.



8 Ways to acquire signatures:

1. STEM Wizard's Paperless Files and Forms:
   - Signee opens the link and completes required information
   - Signee will then save the information
   - This will be available for Junior Division Texas MS Safety and Consent Form and Senior Division ISEF Forms
2. Physically sign the document:
   - Student emails the document to the signee
   - Signee prints the document and signs
   - Signee scans the document and saves as a PDF
   - Signee emails the document back to the student
3. Manually draw signature and scan:
   - Signee writes signature on white paper, take a photo of it, convert jpeg file to png, if needed, and insert image in signature field
   - An electronic signature can be created by using www.createmysignature.com
   - Example shown on the right



4. Microsoft Word:
   - Can create an e-signature using Microsoft Word
5. Mac users:
   - Free s-signature feature
   - Mark-up tool bar
6. Panda doc:
   - Free e-signature plan
   - Supports many documents types
7. Adobe Acrobat:
   - Upload document to acrobat sign
   - Sign up for free account
   - Scroll to page where signature is needed
   - Enter name by typing, drawing, or uploading a signature
   - Example shown on the right



8. Docusign:
   - An interface for sending and signing documents
   - Example shown on the right

Junior Division Forms

Sample Junior Division Texas MS Safety and Consent Form, page 1

Texas MS Safety and Consent Form (JR Division Students must complete all 4 sections)

It is the responsibility of the teacher, parent, and student to make sure that all rules are followed and that the required signatures are obtained for the project prior to experimentation. Projects without completed paperwork will not be allowed to compete.

This document must be completed and signed by student(s), parent(s), teacher, and any other needed signatures **BEFORE** experimentation.

District

School

Teacher Name

Project/Experimentation Start Date

1) Student and Project Information

Team Project | # of Participants

	First Name	Last Name	Grade
1			
2			
3			

Project Title:

Research Location (must be completed for all projects):

Locations: Please list the name and type of location for each place you plan to conduct your research. **If you work or collect data at a place of business or university or you worked with a mentor, you will need to submit a completed Form 1C JR - MS Mentor and Research Location Form as an additional file, and it will need to be displayed at your project booth at the fair.**

Facility Type (check all that apply): Home ☐ School ☐ University ☐ Business ☐ Public Facility (Park, Library, etc) ☐ Other ☐

Location #1 | Location #2

Continuation Project (must be completed for all projects):

Any project that expands on any previous science fair project by changing a variable or adding a new line of investigation

Is this project a continuation from previous year(s)?

If YES, submit your research plan AND abstract from the previous project as an additional file AND explain how this year's project is different.

2) Safety Approvals (must be completed for all projects)

ALL PROJECTS require teacher, parent, and student signatures prior to experimentation. The types of projects listed below require additional pre-approval signatures. **Use SEND LINK button to obtain all required signatures.** Review the complete ISEF rules to see if your project requires other signatures. Check all the boxes below that pertain to your project. Some projects may require more than one additional signature from the persons identified in each category.

☐ **Human Participants** (Example: surveys, taste tests, play a game or interact with another human in any way)

If you are working with humans of ANY age, you need PRE-approval from a School Administrator, AND a Psychologist, Medical Doctor or Registered Nurse to make sure your research is safe. During the review, if it is determined that there is more than minimal risk to the human subjects involved in the project or if the participants are minors, the student must receive written consent from each of the participants and written parental consent for students under 18 years old if required. This includes student researchers experimenting on themselves, testing their product or invention, or being part of the experiment are also human participants.

Additional Required Signatures: School Administrator AND a Psychologist, Medical Doctor, or Registered Nurse

A copy of the surveys or test you intend to use must be submitted as an additional file.

☐ **Non-Human Vertebrate Animals** (Example: fish, rats, rabbits, dogs, cats etc.)

Experiments involving laboratory animals or pets (fish, rats, mice, hamsters, gerbils, rabbits, etc.) cannot be conducted in a student's home except for behavior studies on pets. Proper animal care must be provided daily, including weekends, holidays and vacations. Experimental procedures that cause unnecessary pain or discomfort are prohibited. Experiments designed to kill vertebrate animals are not permitted. Death of any animals due to experimentation will disqualify the project. Behavioral studies or supplemental nutritional studies involving pets or livestock may be done at home. A veterinarian signature is required for experiments that involve supplemental nutrition, administration of prescription drugs and/or activities that would not be ordinarily encountered in the animal's daily life. Other projects may be signed by a Biomedical/Biological Scientist.

Additional Required Signature: Veterinarian or Biomedical/Biological Scientist

☐ **Potentially Hazardous Biological Agents** (Bacteria, Mold, Fungi, Viruses, Parasites, Recombinant DNA (rDNA), Human or Animal fresh tissues, blood or body fluids, etc.)

All Biosafety Level 1 projects can be performed in a school laboratory. **BACTERIA AND MOLD MAY NOT BE GROWN AT HOME.** Standard microbiological practices must be used and all hazardous agents must be properly disposed of at the end of experimentation. The experiment must be supervised by a qualified scientist or a trained designated supervisor.

Additional Required Signature: Biomedical/Biological Scientist

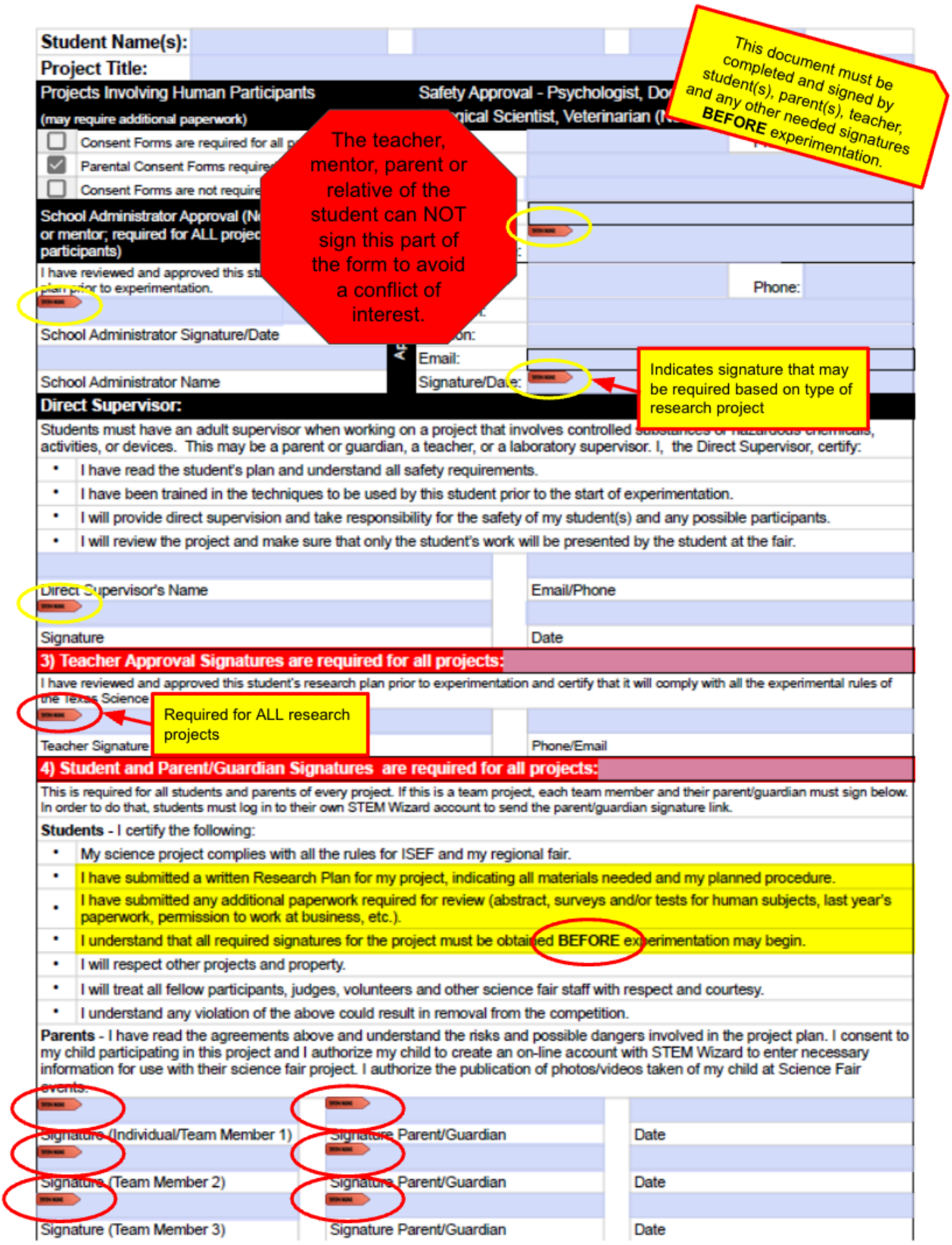
☐ **Hazardous Chemicals, Substances, Activities, or Devices** (Chemicals, power tools, welders, lasers, radioactive substances, radiation)

Students must adhere to federal and state regulations governing hazardous chemicals, substances, activities, or devices. An adult must directly supervise experiments. Students working with hazardous chemicals, substances, activities, or devices must follow proper safety procedures for each chemical or device used in the research.

Additional Required Signature: Direct Supervisor (the adult monitoring the student)

☐ **None of the Above Apply to My Project**

Sample Junior Division Texas MS Safety and Consent Form, page 2



Sample Junior Division Form 2C JR: Middle School Mentor and Research Location Form, Page 1

To be used in Jr. Division if students used a mentor in any way or a Regulated Research Institution. Completed by supervisor/mentor **AFTER** experimentation.

Form 2C JR: Middle School Mentor and Research L

- This form is required for any student who had a mentor (other than teacher or paren other than their home or school, such as a university, lab, business, or other profes
- It must be completed by the mentor, the adult who supervised the student's work at the business owner or manager who gave permission for the student to work at their location — not by
- This form should be filled out **AFTER** the student(s) finishes their research project. However, if the student(s) is required to have permission to work at the facility prior to experimentation (ex. human participant studies at a nursing home or other facility with at risk individuals), then there is an additional signature line available for pre-approval*.

Student Name(s) _____

School _____

Project Title _____

To be completed by the Adult Mentor/Supervisor/Business Owner or Manager:

LOCATION -

Did the student work at your institution or workplace? ☐ YES ☐ NO

If YES, provide the institution/workplace name and address.

_____ _____

Institution/Workplace Name Address

*If approval prior to experimentation is required for the project, and you agree to allow the student to perform their research at your location, please sign here. You will also need to sign at the bottom after experimentation.

_____ _____ _____

Signature Title Date

MENTOR/SUPERVISOR SUPPORT -

Did you or someone at your institution provide mentor support or supervise the student? ☐ YES ☐ NO

If YES, complete the following questions. If NO, skip to the bottom and sign the form.

1. The student's experience included (check all that apply):
   - ☐ Assistance with following the science fair process but no help with actual experimentation
   - ☐ Use of equipment or data from your lab or business
   - ☐ Working as part of a larger research project
   - ☐ Working on their own independent project with minimal help
2. Describe the ways you assisted the student researcher(s) including any materials or data provided.
3. Describe what the student researcher(s) achieved independently or the ideas they contributed (especially how they came up with their question, hypothesis, or design goal).

Sample Junior Division Form 2C JR: Middle School Mentor and Research Location Form, Page 1

4. Describe actions done by the student researcher(s). (For example: collecting data, running tests, using equipment, or making observations. Please note what the student(s) did themselves versus what they only watched.)

5. Did the student(s) work as part of a group? ☐ YES ☐ NO
If YES, were there other students involved? Please list their names and describe how their work was similar or different.

If you checked NO for ALL questions, then you do not need to submit this form.

I confirm that the student completed the work described above and that any required safety or ethics approvals (IRB/IACUC/IBC) have been obtained and are attached if needed.
I understand that the student will be presenting this work at a science fair and that I have discussed any review or publication requirements with them.

Supervising Adult's Printed Name: _____ Signature: _____

Title/Position: _____ Institution or Workplace: _____

Date (after research completed): ____ / ____ / _____ Education/Training/Experie_____

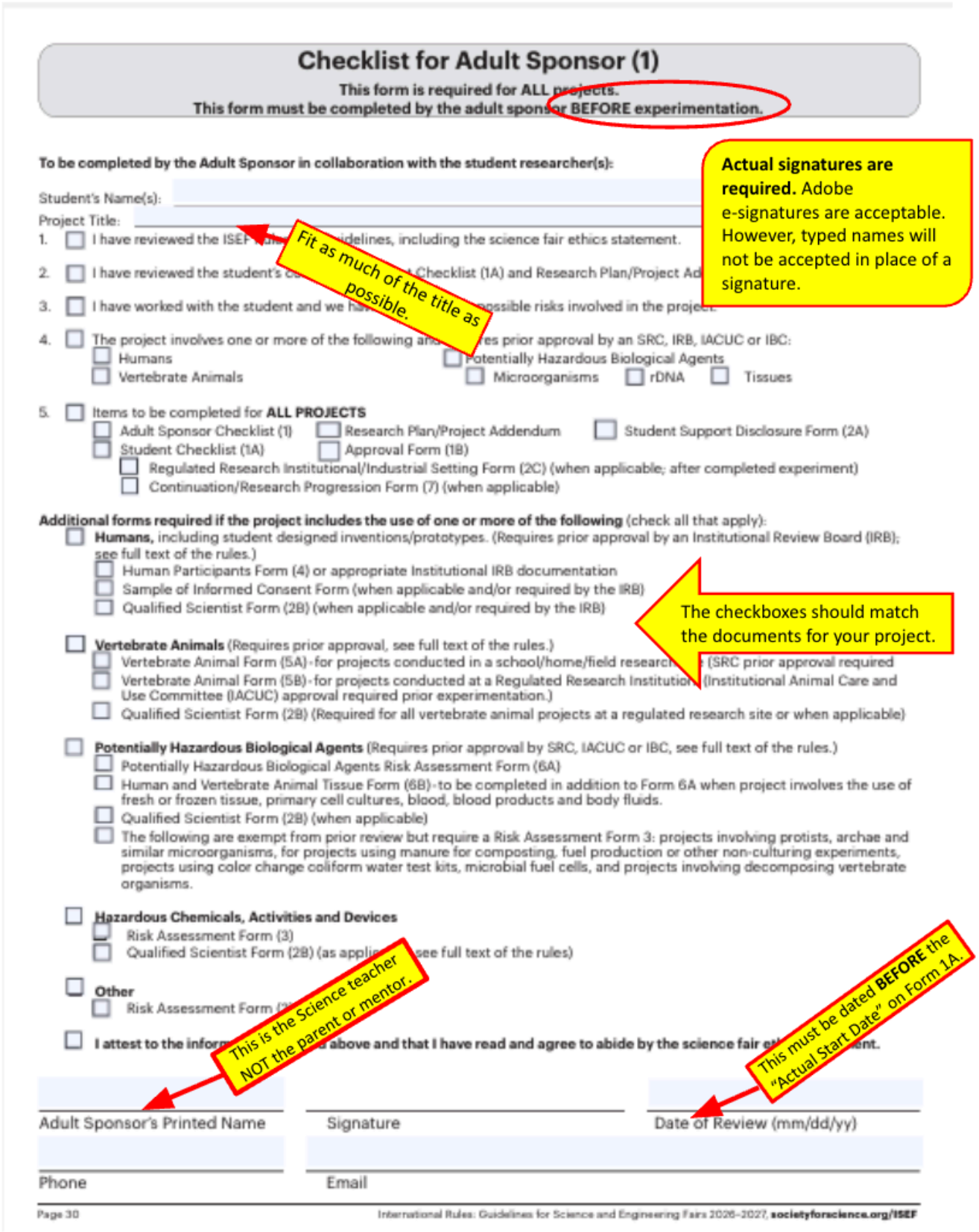
Email/Phone: _____

Completed by Mentor or Supervisor at RRI. Not the teacher.

Senior Division Forms

Checklist for Adult Sponsor (1)

TO FORMS LIST



Checklist for Adult Sponsor (1)

This form is required for ALL projects.
This form must be completed by the adult sponsor BEFORE experimentation.

To be completed by the Adult Sponsor in collaboration with the student researcher(s):

Student's Name(s):

Project Title:

1. ☐ I have reviewed the ISEF rules and guidelines, including the science fair ethics statement.
2. ☐ I have reviewed the student's completed Checklist (1A) and Research Plan/Project Addendum.
3. ☐ I have worked with the student and we have discussed possible risks involved in the project.
4. ☐ The project involves one or more of the following and requires prior approval by an SRC, IRB, IACUC or IBC:
   - ☐ Humans
   - ☐ Vertebrate Animals
   - ☐ Potentially Hazardous Biological Agents
   - ☐ Microorganisms ☐ rDNA ☐ Tissues
5. ☐ Items to be completed for **ALL PROJECTS**
   - ☐ Adult Sponsor Checklist (1)
   - ☐ Research Plan/Project Addendum
   - ☐ Student Support Disclosure Form (2A)
   - ☐ Student Checklist (1A)
   - ☐ Approval Form (1B)
   - ☐ Regulated Research Institutional/Industrial Setting Form (2C) (when applicable; after completed experiment)
   - ☐ Continuation/Research Progression Form (7) (when applicable)

Additional forms required if the project includes the use of one or more of the following (check all that apply):

☐ **Humans,** including student designed inventions/prototypes. (Requires prior approval by an Institutional Review Board (IRB); see full text of the rules.)
- ☐ Human Participants Form (4) or appropriate Institutional IRB documentation
- ☐ Sample of Informed Consent Form (when applicable and/or required by the IRB)
- ☐ Qualified Scientist Form (2B) (when applicable and/or required by the IRB)

☐ **Vertebrate Animals** (Requires prior approval, see full text of the rules.)
- ☐ Vertebrate Animal Form (5A) - for projects conducted in a school/home/field research (SRC prior approval required
- ☐ Vertebrate Animal Form (5B) - for projects conducted at a Regulated Research Institution (Institutional Animal Care and Use Committee (IACUC) approval required prior experimentation.)
- ☐ Qualified Scientist Form (2B) (Required for all vertebrate animal projects at a regulated research site or when applicable)

☐ **Potentially Hazardous Biological Agents** (Requires prior approval by SRC, IACUC or IBC, see full text of the rules.)
- ☐ Potentially Hazardous Biological Agents Risk Assessment Form (6A)
- ☐ Human and Vertebrate Animal Tissue Form (6B) - to be completed in addition to Form 6A when project involves the use of fresh or frozen tissue, primary cell cultures, blood, blood products and body fluids.
- ☐ Qualified Scientist Form (2B) (when applicable)
- ☐ The following are exempt from prior review but require a Risk Assessment Form 3: projects involving protists, archae and similar microorganisms, for projects using manure for composting, fuel production or other non-culturing experiments, projects using color change coliform water test kits, microbial fuel cells, and projects involving decomposing vertebrate organisms.

☐ **Hazardous Chemicals, Activities and Devices**
- ☐ Risk Assessment Form (3)
- ☐ Qualified Scientist Form (2B) (as applicable; see full text of the rules)

☐ **Other**
- ☐ Risk Assessment Form (3)

☐ **I attest to the information above and that I have read and agree to abide by the science fair ethics statement.**

Adult Sponsor's Printed Name | Signature | Date of Review (mm/dd/yy)

Phone | Email

Page 30 International Rules: Guidelines for Science and Engineering Fairs 2026-2027, societyforscience.org/ISEF

Actual signatures are required. Adobe e-signatures are acceptable. However, typed names will not be accepted in place of a signature.

Fit as much of the title as possible.

The checkboxes should match the documents for your project.

This is the Science teacher NOT the parent or mentor.

This must be dated **BEFORE** the "Actual Start Date" on Form 1A.

Student Checklist (1A)

Student Checklist (1A)

This form is required for ALL projects.
This form must be completed by the student(s) BEFORE experimentation.

1. a. Student/Team Leader: _____ Grade: _____
   Email: _____ Phone: _____
   b. Team Member: _____ c. Team Member: _____
2. Title of Project: _____
3. School: _____ School Phone: _____
   (if multiple schools, list of the team leader or list all schools).

School Address: _____

This should be the **teacher.**

4. Adult Sponsor: _____ Phone/Email: _____
5. Where will you conduct your experimentation? (check all that apply)
   ☐ Research Institution ☐ School ☐ Field ☐ Home ☐ Other: _____
6. List the name and address of all non-home whether you worked there virtually or on-site:

   Name _____
   Address _____
   Phone/email _____

A Form 2C is required for a mentor, even if virtual. The rules wizard will only add this if you select research institution or industry setting (place of business).

This should be based on Form 1 responses.

7. Does this project need SRC/IRB/IACUC or other pre-approval? ☐ Yes ☐ No Tentative start date: _____
8. This year's experimentation/data collection:

   This should be the date that the student started collecting data, after approvals.

   _____ _____
   Actual Start Date: (mm/dd/yy) End Date: (mm/dd/yy)

9. Is this a continuation/progression from a previous year? ☐ Yes ☐ No
   a. If yes, attach the previous year's ☐ Abstract **and** ☐ Research Plan/Projec
   b. Explain how this project is new and different from previous years on
   ☐ Continuation/Research Progression Form (7); include forms for all previous years

IF the student has continued his/her project, their paperwork (except Form 7) should focus on the work from the current project cycle.

10. Source of Data:
    ☐ self-collected ☐ mentor collected ☐ publicly available ☐ Other _____

Provide a complete Research Plan/Project Addendum with this form.

International Rules: Guidelines for Science and Engineering Fairs 2026-2027, **societyforscience.org/ISEF** Page 31

Research Plan/Project Addendum Instructions

TO FORMS LIST

Research Plan/Project Addendum

A Research Plan/Project Addendum is required for ALL projects. The plan must be written BEFORE experimentation.

1. The Research Plan is to be written prior to experimentation.
2. If changes are made during the research before competing at an affiliated fair, such changes must be added as an addendum to the original plan. Be aware that some changes may require obtaining or returning to the IRB or SRC for appropriate review and approvals before conducting that portion of the project. If there are no changes, an addendum is not required.
3. The Research Plan/Project Addendum should include the following:
   a. **RATIONALE**: Include a brief synopsis of the background that supports your research question/goal.
   b. **RESEARCH QUESTION(S), HYPOTHESIS(ES), ENGINEERING GOAL(S), EXPECTED OUTCOMES**: Include a brief synopsis of the background that supports your research question/goal.
   c. Describe the following in detail (include any required subject-specific
      - **List of materials:**
      - **Procedures/Methodology:** Detail all procedures and steps of the collection, and when applicable, the source of data used. Be sure are to be taken by any supervising adult(s).
      - **Risk and Safety:** Identify any potential risks and describe safety pr
      - **Data Analysis:** Describe the procedures you will use to analyze the
   d. **ACKNOWLEDGEMENTS:** List all individuals that supported your proje document this support with a prompt log or an explanation of the ele
   e. **BIBLIOGRAPHY:** List major references (e.g. science journal articles, bo all references are properly listed and verified (The use of AI for citation false citations which becomes an ethical issue if you cite sources that

Items 1–4 below are subject-specific guidelines for additional items to be in as applicable.

1. **Human participants research:**
   a. **Participants:** Describe age range, gender, racial/ethnic composition o pregnant women, prisoners, mentally disabled or economically disadv
   b. **Recruitment:** Where will you find your participants? How will they be i
   c. **Methods:** What will participants be asked to do? Will you use any surv did you obtain? Did it require permissions? If so, explain. What is the fr
   d. **Risk Assessment:** What are the risks or potential discomforts (physica participants? How will you minimize risks? List any benefits to society
   e. **Protection of Privacy:** Will identifiable information (e.g., names, teleph Will data be confidential/anonymous? If anonymous, describe how the are in place for safeguarding confidentiality? Where will data be stored the data after the study?
   f. **Informed Consent Process:** Describe how you will inform participants to do, that their participation is voluntary and they have the right to stop at any time.
2. **Vertebrate animal research:**
   a. Discuss potential ALTERNATIVES to vertebrate animal use and present justification for use of vertebrates.
   b. Explain potential impact or contribution of this research.
   c. Detail all procedures to be used, including methods used to minimize potential discomfort, distress, pain and injury to the animals and detailed chemical concentrations and drug dosages.
   d. Detail animal numbers, species, strain, sex, age, source, etc., include justification of the numbers planned.
   e. Describe housing and oversight of daily care.
   f. Discuss disposition of the animals at the end of the study.
3. **Potentially hazardous biological agents research:**
   a. Give source of the organism and describe BSL assessment process and BSL determination.
   b. Detail safety precautions and discuss methods of disposal.
4. **Hazardous chemicals, activities & devices:**
   a. Describe Risk Assessment process, supervision, safety precautions and specific methods of disposal.
   b. Safety Data Sheets must be reviewed and should be referenced but do not need to be submitted with paperwork unless required by your fair.

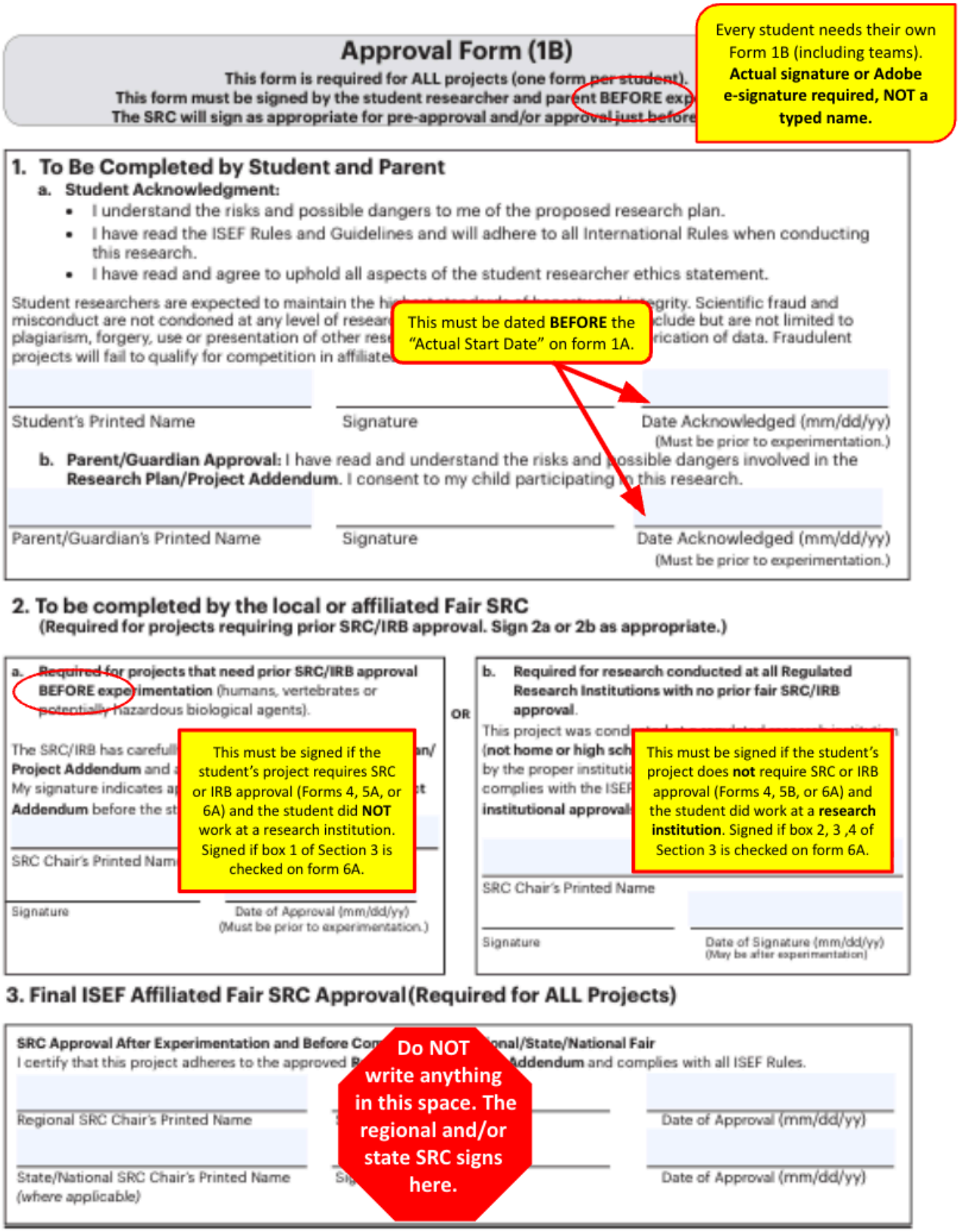
The research plan is the most important document because it provides the regional SRC board the necessary details of the planned research.

This detailed description of the research guides the Scientific Review Committee (SRC) to be able to determine if the proper forms were completed and if they contain the correct information.

It must be VERY detailed and clearly delineate the role of the student vs. the role of the mentor. Use the provided Research Plan template and save it as a PDF.

The entire Research Plan must be in FUTURE tense!!
It must include proposed and actual start and end dates.
It must include a detailed research plan.
It must have all work site information completed.
It must identify student and mentor role.
It must include any use of AI in the procedure, and AI use must be cited.

Approval Form (1B)



Student Support Disclosure Form (2A)

TO FORMS LIST

Student Support Disclosure Form (2A)

This form is required for ALL projects. This form may be completed before or after experimentation.

It is important to fully disclose any support provided in the completion of a scientific research project. This disclosure provides acknowledgment and verification of the project.

To be completed by the student researcher:

Please list the person serving in each role. (Described in the Roles & Responsibilities of Students and Adults section of the Rules.) If an individual serves in multiple roles, list fully once and by name only in other roles.

1. **Adult Sponsor**			
Name	School	Email	Phone
Relationship to student:	Expertise:	Contribution to project:	Duration of support for this project:

This is the **TEACHER**

2. **Direct Supervisor**			
Name			Phone
Relationship to student:		ution to project:	Duration of support for this project:

This is the person who **monitors the experiment process**. Can be teacher if at school, parent if at home, scientist or lab technician if in a lab.

3. **Qualified Scientist**			
Name			Phone
Relationship to student:		o project:	Duration of support for this project:

Applies to some projects that require extra supervision. Must have a graduate degree in the same area of study as the research project.

4. **Additional Supporting Adults** (graduate students, relatives, external experts, etc.) Use additional pages as necessary.			
Name	Organization/School	Email	Phone
Relationship to student:	Expertise:	Contribution to project:	Duration of support for this project:

Paid Support Disclosure:

1. Did you or your parents pay for any support for this project? ☐ Yes ☐ No
   If yes, explain: (Indicate any fees, tuition and/or payment to any of the individuals above and/or to a program that provided any support for this project including lab space, mentorship, documentation preparation, etc.)

AI Usage Disclosure

1. Did your project involve the use of Generative AI? ☐ Yes ☐ No

   If yes, please provide an attachment with Generative AI used in your project and in what elements of your project it was used.

   a. Please provide the AI Prompt Log containing the prompts and responses from the Generative AI or AI Wrapper used. Be sure to remove any personal prompts which contain personal identifying information about yourself or others. If you do not have access to your prompt log, then please provide a summary of the prompts and responses involved in your project.

Attestation by Student Researcher:

I certify that I have presented the full truth regarding all of the support received in the completion of my research project and have not omitted pertinent information nor presented false information.

Finalist Signature: _____ **Date:** _____

Printed Name: _____

Student signs here!

Qualified Scientist Form (2B)

Qualified Scientist Form (2B)

This form is required for projects requiring a Qualified Scientist or Direct Supervisor.
This form must be completed by the Qualified Scientist BEFORE experimentation.

Student's Name(s) _____

Title of Project _____

To be completed by the Qualified Scientist:

Scientist Name: _____

Educational Background: _____ Degree(s): _____

Experience/Training as relates to the student's area of research:

_____ _____

Position/Institution: Email/Phone:

1. Please indicate what the student project will involve:
   a. Human participants ☐ Yes ☐ No
   b. Animals ☐ Yes ☐ No
   c. Potentially hazardous biological agents (microorganisms, rDNA and tissues, including blood and blood products) ☐ Yes ☐ No
   d. Hazardous substances and devices ☐ Yes ☐ No
3. Will this study be a sub-set of a larger study? ☐ Yes ☐ No
4. Will you directly supervise the student? ☐ Yes ☐ No
5. Please describe your anticipated role in this project and the duration of your support.

New question 2027

6. Will you provide any data; if yes, please provide source or describe ☐ Yes ☐ No

To be completed by the Qualified Scientist:

I certify that I have reviewed and approved the Research Plan/Project Addendum prior to the start of the experimentation. If the student or Direct Supervisor is not trained in the necessary procedures, I will ensure her/his training. I will provide advice and supervision during the research. I have a working knowledge of the techniques to be used by the student in the Research Plan/Project Addend

This must be dated **BEFORE** the "Actual Start Date" on Form 1A.

Qualified Scientist's Printed Name

Signature Date of Approval (mm/dd/yy)

To be completed by the Direct Supervisor when the Qualified Scientist cannot directly supervise.

I certify that I have reviewed the Research Plan/Project Addendum and have been tra
used by this student, and I wil

If needed, this must be dated **BEFORE** the "Actual Start Date" on Form 1A.

Direct Supervisor's Printed Name

Experience/Training of Direct Supervisor

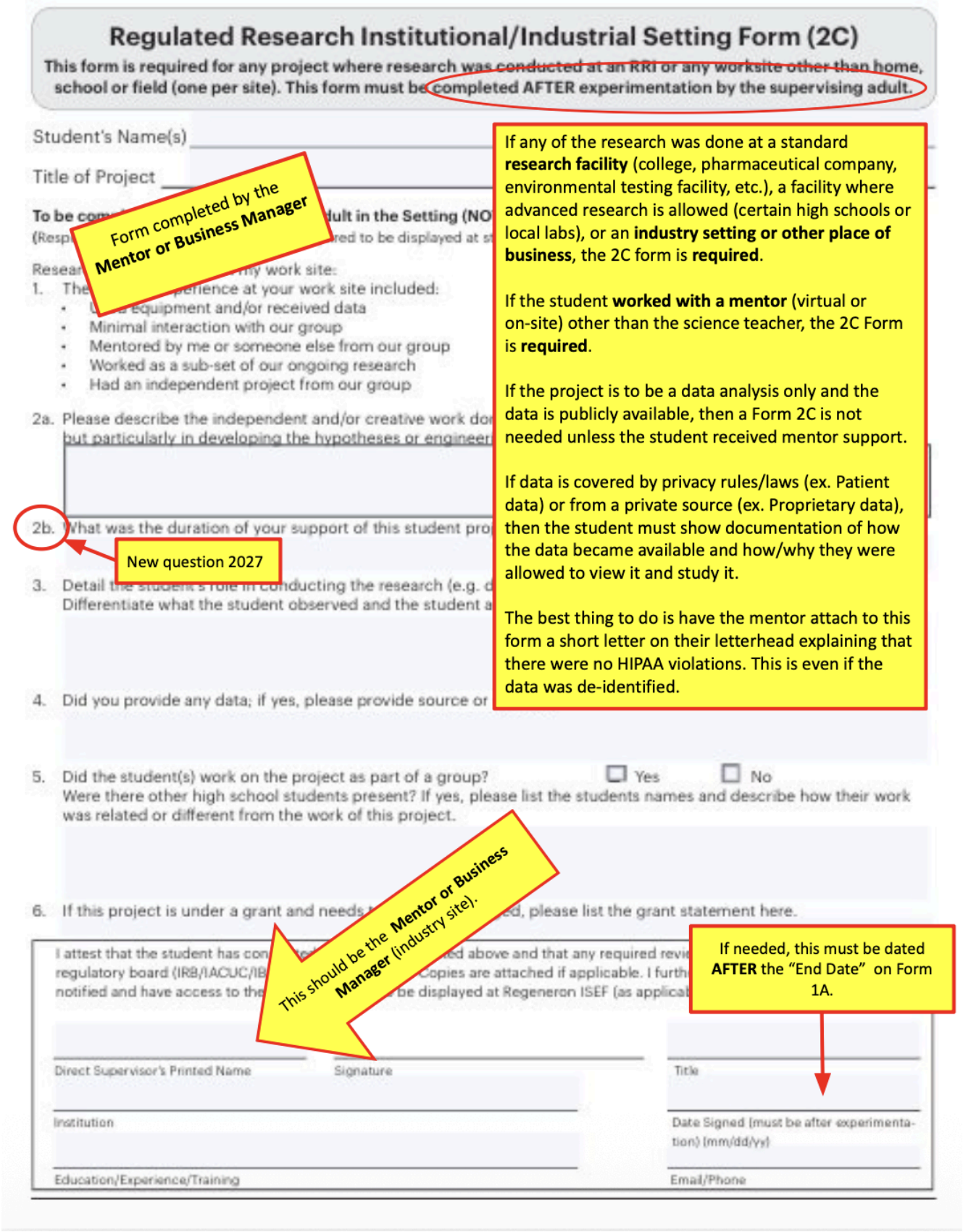
Signature Date of Approval (mm/dd/yy)

Phone email

International Rules: Guidelines for Science and Engineering Fairs 2026-2027. **societyforscience.org/ISEF** Page 35

Regulated Research Institutional/Industrial Setting Form (2C)

TO FORMS LIST



Risk Assessment Form (3)

Risk Assessment Form (3)

This form is recommended for ALL projects; may be required for projects involving hazards, potentially hazardous biological agents or human participants. This form must be completed BEFORE experimentation.

Student's Name(s) _____

Title of Project _____

To be completed by the Student Researcher(s) in collaboration with Direct Supervisor/Qualified Scientist: (All questions must be answered; additional page(s) may be attached.)

1. a) List all hazardous chemicals, activities or devices to be used

   b) List all microorganisms to be used

2. Identify and assess the risks and hazards involved in this project.

3. Describe the safety precautions and procedures that will be used to reduce the risks. If you conducted field work, include permits received and safety plans, as applicable.

4. Describe the specific disposal procedures that will be used (when applicable).

5. List the source(s) of safety information.

To be completed and signed by the Direct Supervisor (or Qualified Scientist,
I agree with the risk assessment and safety precautions and procedures described above. I cer
Research Plan/Project Addendum and the International Rules, including the science fair ethics
direct supervision.

This must be dated **BEFORE** the "Actual Start Date" on Form 1A.

Direct Supervisor's Printed Name _____ Signature _____ Date of Review (mm/dd/yy) _____

Experience/Training as relates to the student's area of research _____

Position/Institution _____ Phone or email contact information _____

Human Participants Form (4)

Human Participants Form (4)

This form is required for all research involving human participants. This form must be completed by the IRB BEFORE recruitment or data collection. (If research is done at an RRI, equivalent RRI IRB documentation is required.)

This form is to be filled out by the SCHOOL or DISTRICT IRB. Be sure that your school IRB is aware of the rules and limitations of student research projects.

For more information and the full list of rules: https://www.societyforscience.org/isef/international-rules/human-participants/

Student's Name(s)

Adult Sponsor

MUST BE COMPLETED BY STUDENT RESEARCHER(S) IN COLLABORAT SCIENTIST:

1. ☐ I have submitted my Research Plan/Project Addendum which a Research Plan/Project Addendum Instructions.
2. ☐ I have attached any surveys or questionnaires I will be using in my project or other documents provided to human participants
   ☐ Any published instrument(s) used was /were legally obtained.
3. ☐ I have attached an informed consent that I would use if required by the IRB.
4. ☐ Yes ☐ No Are you working with a Qualified Scientist? If yes, attach the Qualified Scientist Form 2.

Determined if Form 2B is needed by IRB

BELOW – IRB USE ONLY

Must be checked for any research project using minors

stitutional Review Board (IRB) after review of the research plan. All questions must be answered for the approval to be urn paperwork to the student with instructions for modifications.)

ll Committee Review (3 signatures required) and the following conditions: **(All 6 must be answered)**

heck one) : ☐ Minimal Risk ☐ More than Minimal Risk (a risk assessment form 3 is required)

2. Qualified Scientist (QS) Required (Form 2): ☐ Yes ☐ No
3. Risk Assessment Required (Form 3): ☐ Yes ☐ No
4. Written Minor Assent and written parental permission required for minor participants: ☐ Yes ☐ Not applicable (No minors in this study)
5. Written Informed Consent required for participants 18 years or older: ☐ Yes ☐ No ☐ Not applicable (No participants 18 yrs or older in this study)
6. Facility for "protected groups" used, written approval has been obtained: ☐ Yes ☐ No

Check **Yes** if project is More than Minimal Risk

IRB SIGNATURES (All 3 signatures required) None of these individuals may be the adult sponsor, direct supervisor, qualified scientist or related to (e.g., mother, father of) the student (conflict of interest).

I attest that I have reviewed the student's project, that the checkboxes above have been completed to indicate the IRB determination and that I agree with the decisions above.

Medical or Mental Health Professional (a psychologist, medical doctor, licensed social worker, licensed clinical professional counselor, physician's assistant, doctor of pharmacy, or registered nurse) with expertise related to this project.

Print Name below	Degree/Professional License	
Signature	Date (prior to experimentation)	E

ALL signatures must be dated **BEFORE** the "Actual Start Date" on Form 1A.

The teacher, mentor, parent or relative of the student can NOT sign this form to avoid a conflict of interest.

Educator

Print Name below	Degree/Professional License	
Signature	Date (prior to experimentation)	

School Administrator

Print Name below	Degree/Professional License	
Signature	Date (prior to experimentation)	Email

Human Informed Consent Form

Human Informed Consent Form

This form is a suggested template for written informed consent.
All projects involving minors require written parental permission.

Instructions to the Student Researcher(s): An informed consent/assent/permission form should be developed in consultation with the Adult Sponsor, Direct Supervisor or Qualified Scientist.
This form is used to provide information to the research participant (or parent/guardian) and to document written informed consent, minor assent, and/or parental permission.

- When written documentation is required, the researcher keeps the original, signed form.
- Students may use this sample form or may copy ALL elements of it into a new document.

If the form is serving to document parental permission, a copy of any survey or questionnaire must be attached.

Student Researcher(s): _____

Title of Project: _____

I am asking for your voluntary participation in my science fair project. Please read the following information about the project. If you would like to participate, please sign in the appropriate area below.

Purpose of the project:

If you participate, you will be asked to:

Time required for participation:

Potential Risks (if any):

Potential Benefits (if any):

How confidentiality will be maintained:

If you have any questions about this study, feel free to contact:

Adult Sponsor/QS/DS: _____ Phone/email: _____

This is just an example of a consent form. You MUST submit a copy of whatever consent form will be used and ALL survey questions. If the survey will be done online, submit a copy of all of the consent questions as a part of that survey.

Voluntary Participation:
Participation in this study is completely voluntary. If you decide not to participate there will not be negative consequences. Please be aware that if you decide to participate, you may stop participating at any time and you may decide not to answer any specific question.

By signing this form I am attesting that I have read and understand the information above and I freely give my consent/ assent to participate or permission for my child to participate.

Adult Informed Consent or Minor Assent Date Reviewed & Signed: _____ (mm/dd/yy)

_____ _____

Research Participant Printed Name: Signature:

Parental/Guardian Permission (if applicable) Date Reviewed & Signed: _____ (mm/dd/yy)

_____ _____

Parent/Guardian Printed Name: Signature:

Vertebrate Animal Form (5A)

TO FORMS LIST

Vertebrate Animal Form (5A)

This form is required for all research involving vertebrate animals that is conducted in a school/home/field research site. SRC approval is required BEFORE experimentation.

Student's Name(s) _____

Title of Project _____

Actual signatures are required. Adobe e-signatures are acceptable. However, typed names will not be accepted in place of a signature.

To be completed by Student Researcher:

1. Common name (or Genus, species) and number of animals used.
2. Describe completely the housing and husbandry to be provided. Include the cage/pen size, number of animals per cage, environment, bedding, type of food, frequency of food and water, how often animal is observed, etc. Add an additional page as necessary.
3. What will happen to the animals after experimentation?
4. Attach a copy of wildlife licenses or approval forms, as applicable
5. The ISEF Vertebrate Animal Rules require that any death, illness or unexpected weight loss be investigated and documented by a letter from the qualified scientist, direct supervisor or a veterinarian. If applicable, attach this letter with this form when submitting your paperwork to the SRC prior to competition.

To be completed by Local or Affiliate Fair Scientific Review Committee (SRC) BEFORE experimentation.

Level of Supervision Required for agricultural, behavioral or nutritional studies (select one):

- ☐ Direct Supervisor REQUIRED. Please have applicable person sign below.
- ☐ Veterinarian and Direct Supervisor REQUIRED. Please have applicable persons sign below.
- ☐ Veterinarian, Direct Supervisor and Qualified Scientist REQUIRED. Please have applicable persons sign below and have the Qualified Scientist complete Form (2).

The SRC has carefully reviewed this study and finds it is an appropriate study that may be conducted in a non-regulated research site.
Local or affiliate fair SRC pre-approval signature:

SRC Chair Printed Name | Signatur | Date of Approval (must be prior to experimentation) (mm/dd/yy)

ALL signatures must be dated **BEFORE** the "Actual Start Date" on Form 1A.

To be completed by Veterinarian:

- ☐ I have reviewed this research and animal husbandry with the student before the start of experimentation.
- ☐ I have approved the use and dosages of prescription drugs and/or nutritional supplements.
- ☐ I will provide veterinary medical and nursing care in case of illness or emergency. (Fees may apply.)

Printed Name | Email/Phone

Signature | Date of Approval (mm/dd/yy)

leted by Direct Supervisor or Qualified Scientist when applicable:

- ☐ I have reviewed this research and animal husbandry with the student before the start of experimentation and I accept primary responsibility for the care and handling of the animals in this project.
- ☐ I will directly supervise the experiment.

Printed Name | Email/Phone

Signature | Date of Approval (mm/dd/yy)

Vertebrate Animal Form (5B)

Actual signatures are required. Adobe e-signatures are acceptable. However, typed names will not be accepted in place of a signature.

Vertebrate Animal Form (5B)

equired for all research involving vertebrate animals that is conducted at a RRI. EFORE experimentation. This form must be completed and signed AFTER experimentation.)

Student's Name(s) _____

Title of Project _____

Title and Protocol Number of ~~IACUC Approved Project~~ _____

You MUST attach a copy of the actual IACUC form with the protocol number.

To be completed by Qualified Scientist or Principal Investigator:

1. Species of animals used: _____ Number of animals used: _____

2. Describe, in detail, the role of the student in this project: animal procedures and related equipment that were involved, oversight provided and safety precautions employed. (Attach extra pages if necessary.)

3. Was there any weight loss or death of any animal? If yes, attach a letter obtained from the qualified scientist, direct supervisor or a veterinarian documenting the situation and the results of the investigation.

4. Did the student's project also involve the use of tissues?
   - ☐ ~~No~~
   - ☐ Yes; complete Forms 6A and 6B

Make sure they got these!

5. What laboratory training, including dates, was provided to the student?

6. **Attach a copy of the Regulated Research Institution IACUC Approval.** A letter from the Qualified Scientist or ~~Principal Investigator is not sufficient.~~

This must be dated **AFTER** the "End Date" on Form 1A.

Qualified Scientist/Principal Investigator

Printed Name

Signature

Date (mm/dd/yy)

Potentially Hazardous Biological Agents Risk Assessment Form (6A)

TO FORMS LIST

Potentially Hazardous Biological Agents Risk Assessment Form (6A)

This form is required for all research involving microorganisms, rDNA, fresh/frozen tissue, blood, blood products and body fluids. SRC/IACUC/IBC approval is required BEFORE experimentation.

Student's Name(s)_____

Title of Project_____

To be completed by the QUALIFIED SCIENTIST/DIRECT SUPERVISOR in collaboration with the student researcher(s). All questions are applicable and must be answered; additional page(s) may be attached.

SECTION 1: PROJECT ASSESSMENT

1. Identify potentially hazardous biological agents (PHBA) to be used in this experiment. Include the strain, source, quantity and the biosafety level risk group of each microorganism or tissue.

Local SRC signature is no longer required on Form 6A. However the local SRC must review this form and the research plan prior to signing Form 1B, section 2A.

2. Please indicate the BSL level of the experimentation site:

   ☐ None ☐ BSL-1 ☐ BSL-2

   If BSL-2 laboratory, not at an RRI, include the **BSL-2 checklist**

3. Describe the precautions that will be used to minimize risk.

4. Describe the method of disposal of all cultured materials and other potentially hazardous biological agents.

SECTION 2: TRAINING

1. What training will the student receive for this project?

2. Experience/training of Direct Supervisor as it relates to the student's area of research (if applicable).

SECTION 3: For ALL CELL LINES, MICROORGANISMS AND TISSUES – To be completed by the QUALIFIED SCIENTIST or Direct Supervisor - Check the appropriate box(es) below:

☐ Experimentation on the microorganisms/cell lines/tissues to be used in this study will NOT be conducted at a Regulated Research Institution, but will be conducted at a (check one) __BSL-1 or __BSL-2 laboratory (include a copy of the **checklist for BSL-2**. [This study has been reviewed by the local SRC and the procedures have been approved prior to experimentation.]

☐ This project involves the culturing of Multi Drug Resistant Organisms (MDROs). It has been conducted in a BSL-2 or higher lab at a Regulated Research Institution and the required IBC pre-approval is attached.
Date of IBC approval _____

☐ Experimentation on the microorganisms/cell lines/tissues to be used in this study will be conducted at a Regulated Research Institution and was approved by the appropriate institutional board prior to experimentation; institutional approval forms are attached.
Origin of cell lines:_____ Date of IRC/IBC/IACUC approval _____

☐ Experimentation on the microorganisms/cell lines/tissues to be used will be conducted at a Regulated Research Institution, which does n… …is type of study.

This is the person who monitored the student's experimentation (usually the teacher).

This must be dated **BEFORE** the "Actual Start Date" on Form 1A.

CERTIFICATION – To … …NTIST or Direct Supervisor

The QS/DS has seen this project's research plan and supporting documentation and acknowledges the accuracy of the information provided above. This study has been approved as a (check one) ☐ BSL-1/ ☐ BSL-2 study, and will be conducted in an appropriate laboratory.

QS/DS Printed Name Signature Date of review (mm/dd/yy)

Human and Vertebrate Animal Tissue Form (6B)

Human and Vertebrate Animal Tissue Form (6B)

This form is required for research involving fresh/frozen tissue (including human and/or vertebrate animal established cell lines and tissue culture collections), blood, blood products and body fluids. All projects using any tissue listed above must also complete Form 6A. This form must be completed by the QS/DS BEFORE experimentation.

Student's Name(s) _____

Title of Project _____

Actual signatures are required. Adobe e-signatures are acceptable. However, typed names will not be accepted in place of a signature.

To be completed by Student Researcher(s):

1. What vertebrate animal tissue will be used in this study? Check all that apply.
   - ☐ Fresh or frozen tissue sample
   - ☐ Fresh organ or other body part
   - ☐ Blood
   - ☐ Body fluids
   - ☐ Primary cell/tissue cultures
   - ☐ Human or other primate established cell lines
   - ☐ Vertebrate established cell lines
   - ☐ Exempt tissue (describe):

New options 2027

2. Where will the above tissue(s) be obtained? If using an established cell line include source and catalog number.

3. If the tissue will be obtained from a vertebrate animal study conducted at a research institution attach a copy of the IACUC certification with the name of the research institution, the title of the study, the IACUC approval number and date. If human tissues were used, attach a copy of IRB approval.

To be completed by the Qualified Scientist or Direct Supervisor:

☐ I verify that the student will work solely with de-identified organs, tissues, cultures or cells that will be supplied to him/her by myself or qualified personnel from the laboratory; and that if vertebrate animals were euthanized they were euthanized for a purpose other than the student's research.

AND/OR

☐ I certify that the blood, blood products, tissues or body fluids in this project will be h… standards and guidance set forth in U.S. Occupational Safety and Health Act, 29CFR… Pathogens.

This must be dated **BEFORE** the "Actual Start Date" on Form 1A.

Printed Name _____ Signature _____ Date of Approval (mm/dd/yy) (Must be prior to experimentation.) _____

Title _____ Phone/Email _____

Institution _____

Continuation/Research Progression Projects Form (7)

TO FORMS LIST

Continuation/Research Progression Projects Form (7)

This form is required for projects that are a continuation/progression in the same field of study as a previous project.
This form must be accompanied by the previous year's abstract and Research Plan/Project Addendum.
This form may be completed AFTER experimentation.

Student's Name(s) _____

To be completed by Student Researcher: List all components of the current project that make it new and different from previous research. The current years project should be compared to the immediate previous year (ie. Year 1 to Year 2, Year 2 to Year 3, etc.).

Components	Current Research Project	Previous Research Project: Year: _____
1. Title		
2. Change in goal/ purpose/objective		
3. Changes in methodology		
4. Variable studied		
5. Additional changes		

Continuation projects **MUST** include this form. For the immediately prior year, researcher **MUST** attach BOTH the prior year's Abstract and Research Plan. For any years farther back, the researcher MUST include the Abstract for each additional prior year's work.

A continuation project is one that is built off of work previously performed. Students must show that they are testing a new variable or line of investigation.

Current Year Projects can only present data collected within a 12 month period and not started prior to January 2026.

Attached are:

☐ Previous year's Abstract and Research Plan/Project Addendum, Year _____

☐ Previous Form 7s, if applicable.

This must be dated **BEFORE** the "Actual Start Date" on Form 1A.

I hereby certify that the above information is correct and that the current year Abstract & Certification and project display board properly reflect work done only in the current year.

Student's Printed Name(s) _____ Signature _____ Date of Signature (mm/dd/yy) _____